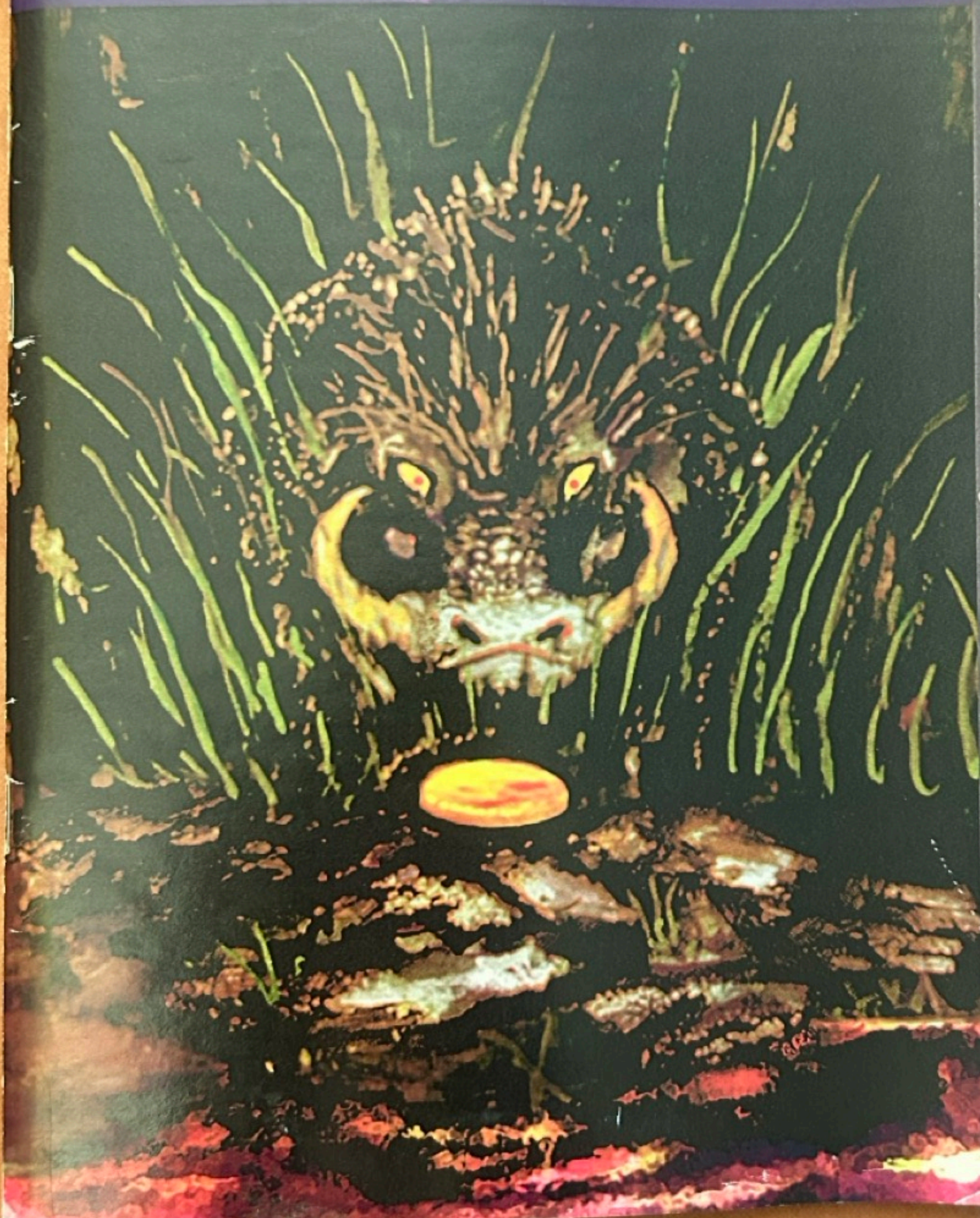


the floating liars' club
inaugural issue

october 2002

\$4.50

shannon rampe - joe bellomy - ben crites - nathan mc knight



*Well, there're bumblebees and sage
and ponds and kids swimming.
There're broken monitors and spare
parts and grease and rusty, knuckle-
breaking bolts and bookstores and
endless cups of coffee. Cigarettes,
stained glass, dresses, holes-in-one,
and Serena's skintight, black tennis
uniform; there's a lost wrench, a lost
sock, lost key, infinite shades of green.
There's misspelling and curses and
witches, hookers, businessmen, horse
trainers, candy shop owners and evil
clowns. There are secrets. Some things
never said. Impossible to say. Vocabu-
lary. Voice boxes. Muscles, punctua-
tion, Marilyn Monroe, Caesar, Jesus
and Groucho Marx. There is a Charo
and a painted stone sitting in a flower
pot. An ashtray, cicadas. There's a guy
I know...a thought I had...a dream I
dreamt...*

And then there's fiction.

-Joe Bellomy

or two of the glowing admiration of his peers before his writhing stops and they bury him in a mound of sacred dirt beyond a river," Bobby said. He looked off into the night for the hovering lions of fear he had lived with.

"Is that true? I didn't know that," the mustachioed man said, unbuttoning his fly. His gut seeped like an avalanche over his waistline and he burped some more. Light from a citronella candle whipped across his bulbous nose.

Deeder marched out the sliding door, clapped his hairy hands together and rubbed them. A penlight clamped like a stogie in the side of his mouth muffled his speech. "Ready, Wallace? Man, this is something." He sauntered off the patio into the darkness of his thick lawn and the beating rhythm of crickets. Wallace stumbled behind him, spilling beer on his jean shirt. Deeder's excited voice echoed in the woods in front of them.

"Bastard's eaten half of my turnip crop, most of my beets," Deeder said.

Wallace's heart started jumping. He watched Deeder knock off the lid of the trashcan. It was full of water dark as the Congo, and when Deeder flashed his penlight into the murkiness of it, Wallace saw the faint traces of a steel object. Maybe it was a Z-2957 steel grate Deeder swiped from work, he thought. A wet strand of rope extended out of the depth and Deeder fished out a wire trap with a drowned ground hog inside, its mouth frozen open in its last struggle for oxygen. Its eyes had the vacant look of something stuffed.

"You son of a bitch," Deeder said. "I bet it has some of my turnips in its stomach. Want to check?"

"Nah," Wallace said, though he thought, "Christ, what kind of twisted shit, this man kills over beets and turnips."

"They're not clever, these groundhogs," Deeder said and twirled the trap on the rope. Water dripped from the soggy marmot and made tiny plops in the trashcan.

Wallace stood on the patio under a lamp where a cloud of gnats swarmed and stuck on the sweat of his skin. Bobby still patrolled the yard's dark shadows from the webbed lawn chair. Wallace said his goodbyes, using his wife as an excuse for leaving, even though he stayed later than everyone else and didn't need an excuse. His heart pounded against the bony bars of his rib cage and he placed his hand against it.

"You all right, Wally?" Deeder asked.

"Ah, it's nothing. Mild arrhythmia, maybe. Afraid Martha will be after me for being gone so late, I guess," Wallace said.

"She still upset?" Deeder asked.

Wallace paused. He dug his hand into his pocket.

"She might divorce me. She says she doesn't know."

"Don't sweat it. Seems to me that she would've done it by now if she was going to."

"Yeah," Wallace said and for a moment he teetered in the porch light, feeling ashamed to talk about it, struggling against the maudlin sentimentality he kept hidden from men. Sometimes beer loosened those defenses, but he quit drinking a while ago and felt tired. Still, his heart jumped and his nerves were edgy.

"You know in Sudan you can get an experienced woman for a cow. Ten cows will get you a virgin, though few people own ten cows over there," Bobby said.

Wallace staggered, staring down at a strange concrete goose dressed in a red, white, and blue apron. He watched it get closer as he fell; his skull thumped against it.

Wallace drove home with an ice pack pressed to his temple, embarrassed because of the small talk about his sleeping around, embarrassed because he fell. When he had opened his eyes, he saw the shadowy figure of Deeder's wife nursing the cut on his forehead with a warm rag and he wasn't sure if she was a woman he had just slept with.

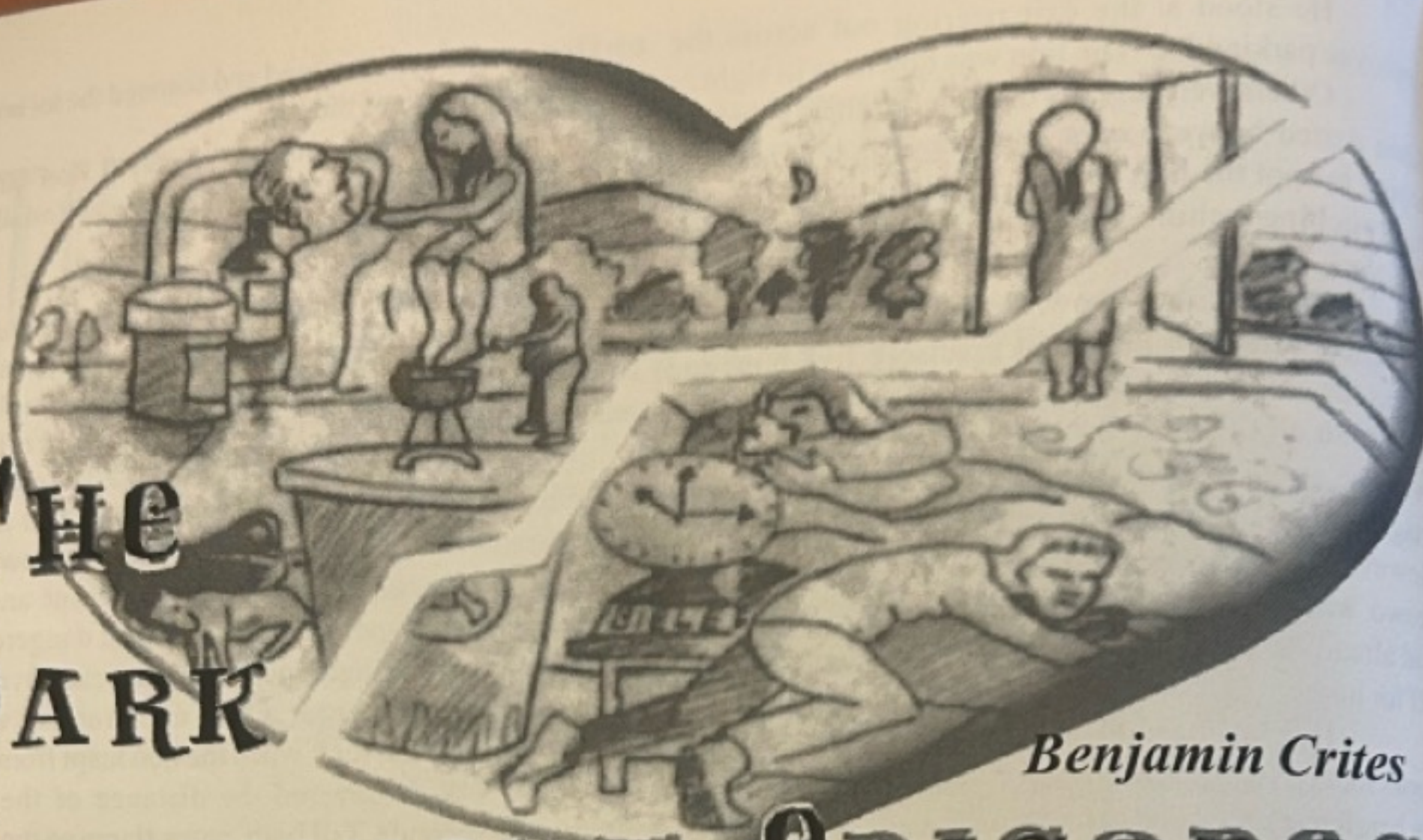
The second episode occurred at work a few weeks later.

"Martha didn't come home last night," Wallace said biting into an apple in the break room. A man wheeled a dolly full of candy bars and various snacks to replenish the vending machine. Deeder flipped through the Metro section of the newspaper. Residue of macaroni and cheese hardened in a plastic bowl in front of him.

"I'm thinking of buying a truck. It'd be nice to have something to lug mulch or dirt in, what have you. Think these people are reliable," Deeder said. "I'm always on all fours when buying a car. Criminal bastards." He looked up at the vending man as if he didn't want to include him in Wallace's conversation.

"I don't know if she'll come back," Wallace

*The fitful engineer
led the mob into the
stockroom and they
enclosed around
Deeder...*



THE DARK

CONTINENT EPISODES

Benjamin Crites

The first episode occurred shortly after Wallace cheated on his wife.

It crept on him at a barbecue his co-worker Marty Deeder held in celebration of his son Bobby's return from two years in Sudan where he educated a ravaged third-world town with the Peace Corps. Wallace and Deeder treated each other like war buddies because they spent their days holed up in the stockroom of Energy Robotics. Wallace shelved and catalogued all the intricate parts to the machines while Deeder stretched tape over cardboard box flaps as though they were mouths he wanted to silence.

Bobby looked awkward, Wallace felt, watching him hold his can of Molson as though it were contaminated, like it was some cheap toy dangling from the claw of one of those grab machines. The kid nodded in turn to each relative circled around him at his nylon lawn chair. Wallace sipped on a beer and stood beside Deeder at the grill. Deeder poked at chicken breasts with metal tongs. He narrated his grilling technique for perfectly glazed chicken and ribs. To really lock in the flavor, Deeder said, you lightly coat the meat as you cook it, like staining your deck, it needs a couple coats, he said.

Wallace scanned the reaches of Deeder's back yard; the wooded area at the far perimeter, the lines of pear saplings doctored up with support boards, the shed stolen from a Norman Rockwell painting. He was particularly intrigued with a heavy-duty garbage can that stood beside a rectangular garden, budding with broccoli and cauliflower. On the garbage can was

a poison emblem, the cross bones and freakish skull spray painted white.

"Say, Deeds, what's with the trash can?" Wallace asked. He hiccupped from the carbonated kick of canned beer. Deeder looked up from the grill and squinted suspiciously over the hickory smoke, meat sizzling below.

"Now that's something," Deeder said. "After dinner." He nodded in affirmation of the greatness of the trashcan, proud as though his bowling trophy was encased in Styrofoam peanuts inside. Deeder clamped a blackened breast and dropped it on a ceramic platter.

After the meal, the sluggish crowd began to disperse, full with drink and grilled fowl. The party fizzled into a slow denouement, a tired procession of "thank you" and "we should be going" of the bloated lot, struggling home to recliners and sedative televisions. Bobby sat motionless in the lawn chair, shell shocked it seemed. A patio barbecue had become foreign and he wasn't sure how to act, Wallace thought. His neglected beer can still hung from his fingertips like he didn't know it was there. Some women argued inside over who would do the dishes, each aggressively volunteering, each trying to convince the other to let them do it. A mustachioed man lingered and huddled up to Bobby, lending his ear to stories of the Dark Continent. The man groaned and burped and described how full he was.

"You know in Sudan there's a ritual every year where the men of the tribe drink milk until they burst, literally. The winner is treated with great respect, but only gets a moment

He stood at the exit peering out across the employee parking lot. The lion was nowhere in sight.

Others were already dashing for their vehicles. Some darted between cars, clutching their briefcases hoping to spot the lion before it spotted them. It could be crouching behind that blue BMW or that grey Chrysler.

Arnold didn't know. He did know the doors of the office were auto locked at precisely five p.m. and unless the cat took someone else soon he'd be running for it with all the other schmucks. He thought a bit of overtime might give him an edge. Maybe the cat would snag another while he was still exiting the building. However, the delay may have worked against him. The crowd was thinning now and the quickest employees had already made it to their vehicles and were speeding off for home.

He glanced at his watch. In moments when the doors locked he'd have to run for it anyway. So he tucked his briefcase up under his arm and made a dash for the first row of parking spaces.

There was a time when he'd been the first out of the building. Almost daring the cat to make a go for him. Now though, after years with the company, he felt a bit old and knew he was slower than he'd ever been.

Yesterday a senior VP had been snagged. He hadn't even been able to disarm his auto alarm before the lion was on him. He'd crumbled under the weight of the lion and had disappeared beneath its huge frame and full mane. Lucky for him he'd known the magic word and upon speaking it the lion released him with only the slightest bit of damage.

Arnold knew the magic word also. But that was small comfort. It might work, it might not.

He gained the first row easily. One man skittered passed, eyes wide in terror, apparently he forgot where he parked and was now running haphazardly around searching for his car.

Arnold crouched near a Chevy, then quickly trotted toward a blue Mazda in the second row of the

parking lot. He took a second and scanned the lot hoping to catch a glimpse of the cat.

"Get the fuck out of the way!" Ron Sumner shouted as he pushed by. Arnold moved and Ron slipped quickly into his mini van.

Arnold made for the third row.

What was that? A blur of movement to the right.

Doors slammed, engines started, wheels squealed and transmissions whined as employees reached the safety of their vehicles and sped off.

Now Arnold was getting scared. The crowd was thinning and the lion had yet to show itself. It must be stalking someone particular. Beyond the third row of cars was the grassy median between the front and back parking lot. This open area was the most dangerous and the great cat had caught more than one employee here.

He stopped near a Ford Explorer and was just about to make a run for it when the lion leapt from behind a yellow VW. It covered the distance of the grassy median on seconds. Tail high, paws slapping the ground its mane fluttered with the speed of its attack.

Arnold held up his briefcase trying to deflect the attacking feline but it did nothing to slow the force of three hundred pounds of fluff and muscle.

They rolled to the ground, the cat's maw firmly gripping his shoulder.

Arnold froze. The cat's sharp teeth pressed into his shoulder.

What was it? He thought frantically. The cat gently mawed his neck as if savoring the taste before biting straight into the meat.

What was it? What was it? What was the word.

The lion bore over him holding him down with one massive paw.

"Tilt," Arnold said remembering what the VP had told him. The magic word was tilt. "Tilt...tilt...tilt..." he repeated.

But it did not seem to be working.

joe bellomy

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The Lion In the Parking Lot



THE LION IN THE PARKING LOT

Joe Bellomy



the floating liars' club

inaugural issue - october 2002



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Submit!

the floating liars' club is now taking submissions for upcoming issues.

We will consider well-written short fiction and poetry of all forms and genres, and we are especially interested in talented new writers from central Ohio.

We accept email submissions only, except by special arrangement.

All submissions and queries should be sent to: floatingliarsclub@hotmail.com

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A product of Columbus, Ohio.

Handwritten red ink scribbles, possibly a signature or initials.

said.

Deeder folded the section and set it sliding amongst the rest of the paper on the table. He poured a cup of coffee and leaned against the countertop. "She'll be back." He cleared his throat. "You know how it is with women. They want you feeling the same way they do and if you don't you have to pretend to, just to keep them cool on the matter. Look, she's just trying to make you hurt. You know." He fiddled with a straw, avoiding looking directly at Wallace.

The hands on the clock made minute movements on the wall. Whenever Wallace itched to be home he found himself more aware of that clock, its black and white school day complacency.

"Hey, my boy got his slides back from the photo shop. Going to give us a presentation on his Sudanese adventures. Got an unopened bottle of Crown. You in?" Deeder asked.

Wallace fell quiet. He tormented himself with memories, his own slideshow of episodes of his love and marriage to Martha. The red second hand ticked in fruitless circles. Wallace thought maybe she had gone to her sister's. He hated how she involved her family in their problems. Wallace didn't even remember the circumstances of that night at the hotel when he squandered the peacefulness of his routine. Every word he shared with his wife since then was delicately chosen and every action done considerably to avoid any blow up. He wondered if the Gideon's wasn't in a drawer, if he saw it on the nightstand, would he have followed through with it?

To Wallace, his cheating wasn't out of spite or unhappiness, but temptation. It was nothing malicious, really, just a taste of something else like choosing the kettle chips over the Cheetos from the vending machine. It was a spontaneous temporary craving for something different. No preconceptions. No voice in his stupefied mind stopped him.

Now he wanted everything back. He wanted to stop wondering what she thought in the silence they shared during Letterman. During the intense quiet of breakfast their conversation was clanking spoons in ceramic bowls, forks scraping against plates. He heard every eggshell crack.

That afternoon in the stock room, while penitently waiting on the clock, Wallace felt flushed and his heart rate again increased. He pushed a cart full of random screws, fuse boards, electrical wires, and steel girders through the towering aisles of the stockroom while Deeder typed in inventory product codes at a computer.

Through the gaps between the shelves, Wallace marveled at the sprays of sparks bursting in the engineers' work area. They were goggled madmen, he thought, welding futuristic machines implemented by major corporations to test the durability of microchips. That was the extent of what Wallace and Deeder really knew about it, though. It was often a mystery they joked about.

Wallace watched one of the engineers throw down his goggles and panic, searching the contents of a cardboard

box for something. A group of engineers huddled around him. Some looked with him, but their effort was unproductive and the group of them turned toward the stock room with scorn. Wallace ducked down behind his cart and thought, fuck, the Z-2456s, fuck. His heart trembled.

The fitful engineer led the mob into the stockroom and they enclosed around Deeder, furtively seeking out explanations. The engineer slapped down a form beside him.

"Z-2456. So," Deeder said.

"You got any in?" The engineer asked. Wallace knew this pseudo-catechism was simply for effect. Deeder typed in the code.

"No, nothing."

"Yeah, nothing," the engineer said. The group around him crossed their arms, some sneered. "Nothing. Exactly what we can do without the order of these I submitted a week and a half ago. They only take three days Airborne Express, Marty." The engineer looked back at his gaggle that nodded in unison.

"This puts us behind schedule. This fucks us, Marty.

Why the fuck isn't our shipment here?"
"Wallace, you know anything about a Z-2456 order?" Deeder asked.

"Z-2456," Wallace said, his voice cracking with pubescent like inflections. He swallowed hard and thought his heart was going to push through his chest and gargle like the mangled creature from Alien. "Nah, don't know anything about any Z-2456s," Wallace said.

"You put the order form in the basket?" Deeder asked the engineer.

"Yes, I put it in the fucking basket a week and a half ago."

"You better stop sassing me. I don't like the way you're talking."

The engineers began to disperse. As they walked away, the fitful engineer flailed his arms and yelled, "Fucking incompetence." That was enough for Deeder, who tackled the engineer from behind and smashed his face into the ground a couple of times before the others pulled him off, before Wallace passed out.

Oars splashed against the current. Men in safari fatigues lined both sides of the boat and chanted to the clamor of a kettledrum. Wallace perched on the stern, his thumbs entwined in his ammunition belt. The boat jerked underneath him, shifting away from the shore. He looked up from his snakeskin boots to the black shoreline far off in the distance. An iridescent glow of purple fringed on the skyline made the black mass of land look like a giant raven on its back; its belly the curve of clouds in the gloaming. The boat jerked away.

"You all right?" somebody asked him. "Hey, Wallace. You Okay?"

Oolee turned and ran back to the stairs. She didn't know if they were following, and didn't wait to find out. Back at the village center, she found the priest studying in exactly the same place he'd been when she left with her slate and knife.

The priest's body filled most of the little hall. With his breasts, and a belly that completely engulfed his manhood, he might easily be mistaken for a female. He spent most of his time in the village center and the temple, writing and reading and practicing his oration.

"The boys won't let me go to sleep."

"Oolee, calm." The priest wrinkled his brow in an expression of deep concern, then he said, "are you trying to sleep with the goats again?"

"Yes, but they threw mud at me."

"Now, it's okay. I told them to make sure you were going to join the other children for sleep. They were doing my bidding."

"Why did you tell them to make fun of me?"

The priest chuckled. "I didn't tell them anything of the sort. I think those two just take their duties too seriously. Now, go off to the sleep chambers and rest with everybody else."

"They'll make fun of me-my fur." Oolee subconsciously stroked the soft hair on her arms.

"Now, just because you're different doesn't mean they're better than you."

"Tell that to them."

"Why don't you tell them that long ago, everybody had fur-even on their heads. Even more than your father."

"They won't believe me."

"Oolee. Do as I say. You know that it's okay. Your hair is yours. You are fine. You are yourself, that's all anybody can ask you to be. Do as I say, and go sleep."

Oolee knew obstinacy was an impiety. She bit her lip, trying not to cry. She was nearing the coming of age. It wouldn't do to show such emotion in front of the priest. To do so would be to risk being left out of the upcoming ceremony.

* * *

Oolee woke amid a writhing mat of humanity. The bald children slid over one another like worms. Her wispy hairs stuck to her skin. An elbow poked her cheek. Her leg was asleep under another child's. All the children slept in the alleyways surrounding the village center. She felt out of place. Even more so than when she helped in the shearing and butchering, or when she sat among them hairless children in the schoolroom. Their skin was so different from her own. It was so beautifully pale and smooth while hers was speckled and brown, disgustingly marred by ugly fur.

Slowly, she pulled herself out from the wakerife masses. Some of the children were just getting up too. Others,

just laying down. The alleys were never free of sleeping youngsters. Never, except during a ceremony.

Oolee jumped up to catch the edge of one of the houses that overlooked the village center. Pulling herself up, she saw that the priest had gone, although the fire was still blazing. He had probably taken a walk to the water treacle or the smokehouse. She didn't dare go back down to the goat pen and risk the priest's anger.

Instead, Oolee slinked up the stairs. Soon, she'd be out of sight, lost in the perpetual smoke cloud. The walk brought her into a warm loft that overlooked the whole village. Smoke obscured most of the details—the goats and open-roofed cottages—but lights formed curtains up and down the village's slope. The cavern walls stretched smoothly up, forming an arch above the village. The arch held in the smoke that poured from the hearths. Only at a fissure in the cave, where Oolee was now, did the smoke find escape.

*They turned her
name into a
taunt. She
stopped, held
her knife behind
her back...*

-13-

Above the village the fissure opened into a series of smooth and even tunnels. They were glassy and colorful, unlike anything in the village below. She admired the artwork; black and green squares alternating to form stripes and in places, stippled illustrations of faces and things she didn't recognize. Leading into the temple was a big doorway not far from the fissure.

The climb had taken the sleep out of her to somewhat, though she still had a few yawns left. At least up here there would be no children, she thought. Nobody came up here before a ceremony, not when there was important work to do below.

The priest had given her some work to do here so she could avoid the cruelty of the children and the whispers of the adults. The temple of the Angry God was bigger than any



Eye of the Angry God

Nathan McKnight

The goats slept fitfully, dreaming whatever it was that goats dreamt. They formed a warm, fidgeting pile, undulating with the sighs of sleep. Oolee embraced a small kid. The dreams of the goats failed to disturb her. It was the yeening noises of a nanny goat that raised her from her hard fought nap. She pulled herself out of the fold. Itchy and bleary-eyed, she picked her way through the pen. She wanted to try on her Celebration outfit, but she knew the priest wouldn't let her until she'd finished her lesson.

* * *

Oolee sat crosslegged on the edge of a landing near the goat pens. The staircase was a series of broad terraces; soil packed hard behind dams of wood. There were saddles worn deep into each, giving the whole a sagging appearance. It stretched perhaps a thousand flights above her and nearly the same below. The great staircase dwarfed the whole village, climbing up and out through fissures in the cave ceiling, and terminating in a pool of cess at the village foot.

People milled around on the higher landings, some robed, returning from the ceremonies, others nude and informal. Oolee practiced her letters, yawning. She carved with a little

knife in the foot-polished dirt, but she had trouble focusing on her monochromatic slate. Deciding that she'd gotten up too early, she hurriedly cut the last few letters of the alphabet and scrimmed back to the goat pens.

The village had many pens—they traded meat, milk, and pelts for food-moss and fish cultivated by those who lived in the deeper villages of Parthenon, and Fleet, and the others. Oolee's goats, her only inheritance from her father, were penned at his abandoned house. As she approached, she noticed two boys prodding at the animals with their fingers. They wiped mud on the goats' white curls.

"Oolee Ooleeeleee," they turned her name into a taunt. She stopped, held her knife behind her back.

"Ooleeeleeeeee, Goat girl, come and sleep with the goats, goat girl."

"Go away," she said in as deep a voice as she could muster. She tried to imitate the priest's booming as it echoed around the chapel walls. "I've got a knife."

"Oh no, Oolee's got a knife," said one of the boys. "What're you gonna do, shear the goats, or shear yourself?" the other asked. They both let out high-pitched giggles. One of them, the taller of the two, flung a wad of mud at her.

He retrieved a wheelbarrow from the garage. When he came sprinting back with it, he stopped and momentarily rested with his hands on his knees, his face flushed, an aurora of light pulsed in the darkness of his closed eyes.

He wedged his hands under the dog and hoisted it up into the wheelbarrow. A hot flash of pain blasted in the small of his back. The dog cried and kicked its legs; its nails scraped his gut. He fumbled over the wheelbarrow. Martha's voice was faint behind him, asking him if he was okay. Wallace ran across the street, pushing the wheelbarrow in front of him. He felt something give inside of him.

Everything blended. All the insect songs, the water rushing sound of the wind blowing in the trees, the dark sky and cold lawns, all bleared and swirled like a child's finger painting that Wallace thought to himself as the closing episode of his life. He fainted. The wheelbarrow skidded on its metallic elbows, spitting sparks until it hit the curb and the Foxhound tumbled out onto the sidewalk.

Wallace awoke the next morning to fragments of light burning through the blinds. Martha sat on the edge of the bed. She leaned over him, her breasts draping into him as she felt his

forehead. She smiled weakly and shook her head. Wallace felt the stinging of strawberries patched on his knees and scrapes on his face. Martha wet a rag in the bathroom and pressed it against his cuts.

"I spoke with the doctor," she said in a soothing tone. "It's time to take these," she said and twisted the cap off the Klonopin. She put one in his mouth and grabbed a glass of water. He held his hand up to halt her.

"The dog made it," she said, "though I can't tell which damaged it more - me hitting it with the car, or you throwing it onto the sidewalk."

The pill tasted like glue and became wet and sticky on Wallace's tongue.

"I'm sorry," Wallace said. Speaking with the pill in his mouth he sounded like he had bitten his tongue. He grabbed Martha's hand and squeezed it.

"It'll take a while for it to heal, but it's going to be all right," she said.

She pressed the glass to Wallace's lips and a gentle stream of water carried the pill in a cooling sensation over the dry and brittle passage of Wallace's throat, chilling the steady rhythm of his heart. Wallace closed his eyes in relief, ready to sleep again.



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"Kid's different ever since he's been back. He just sits there and doesn't say shit," Deeder whispered. He shook his head after a long reflective gaze at his son. "When he does, it's nonsense."

"About today, Deeds," Wallace said.

"Screw it. It's in the past and better left that way. What's dead should stay dead."

"There's something you should know."

"Nah. No sense revisiting that now. Come on in and have a seat. We'll get us a couple of glasses. We'll drink until we forget about it. You ready in there, Bobby?"

"Shuakhwe," Bobby said.

"What did he say?" Wallace asked.

Deeder slapped a tray of ice cubes against the countertop and cubes flopped out and slid across it. He tried to grab a handful but some errant cubes slipped further across the counter.

"I'm telling you, Wally, something's wrong with that kid," Deeder said.

There was mud crusted on Bobby's sneakers and up his shins on his pant legs. There was black residue crusted under his eyes that looked like mascara.

Deeder grunted as he sat on the couch. He unsheathed the Crown from its majestic purple bag and filled the two glasses. Bobby turned off the light and flashed the first slide via a remote changer.

The picture was of an African woman whose earlobes had been stretched all the way down the side of her face to her chin line. She wore a light gauzy wrapping, which you could see the entire shape of her breasts and nipples through.

The second slide featured the same woman. This time she hunkered down by a bunch of emaciated children. She smiled, flashing large rows of chalky teeth. Bobby proceeded through twenty slides of this woman in various poses, smiling her big smile. Deeder took a large gulp of whiskey.

"You got pictures of anything else, Robert?" he asked.

"Shuakhwe," Bobby said. He clicked to another slide. It was a headshot of the woman. Her brown eyes stared intently at the three of them.

"Next," Deeder said.

Bobby stared into the grains of the projection screen. Dust motes tumbled in the beam of light.

"Next slide."

Bobby leaned forward, his elbows on his kneecaps. He had a dreamy expression. He stared for a long time, inspecting every fleck of the woman's eyes. He fell back into the chair, his arms dangling and his head tilted to the side.

"Ah, Raheem. The weather is so cold here," he said. "Africa is not the dark continent. The past is."

Wallace put his hand in his pocket and wrinkled his pharmacy receipt between his thumb and forefinger.

Deeder looked at Wallace and rolled his eyes. He slammed his glass down on the coffee table.

"God damnit, Bobby, you've gotten strange!" he said. He grabbed the remote but Bobby wouldn't let go of it. Wallace watched two struggling shadows on the projection screen.

"Give it here, Bobby!"

"Shuakhwe. I'm Shuakhwe!"

Deeder pushed his son down into the chair and raised his fist above him. For a while, he held Bobby like that, his face crunched into a sour expression again. He squeezed his fist and just when Wallace thought he'd bring the hammer down, Deeder retreated down the hallway. A door slammed. Bobby began to well up. He sniffled, stood up and adjusted his pants, dry flakes of mud falling to the carpet. He walked out the front door.

During the scuffle, Deeder had pressed the clicker several times and a picture of a wild boar in some flimsy reeds was projected on the screen. Its menacing eyes glared over its tusks. There was what looked like a large golden coin in front of the boar, but the boar just stood there looking at Wallace, begging him to go for the coin.

In the driveway, Bobby sat in his idling jeep. He looked in the rearview mirror and smeared paint on his face. Wallace stood outside the jeep and looked in at Bobby. He had made a fierce mask with splotches of white, red, black, and gray. He looked at Wallace, nodded at him, and flashed on his headlights. To the erratic rhythm of tribal drums, Bobby peeled out of the driveway and disappeared around the bend into the moonless night.

Wallace's house was dark and vacant. He sat the bottle of pills on the countertop with a Xerox of the medication instructions. He poured a glass of bourbon, placed it beside the pills, and then thumbed through the paper to see what was on TV. Finding nothing that interested him, he folded the paper and reached for the bourbon. The front door opened.

"Wallace," Martha yelled. "Wallace, are you here?"

"Martha."

"Wallace, come out front, quick. I've hit a dog."

Across the street a Foxhound writhed in the dry leaves bunched by the Petersons' brick mailbox. Its legs moved as though it were dreaming of the prairie hills where it chased woodcock and pheasant. There was blood coming out of its nose and eyes, which bulged like fried egg yolks. There wasn't a collar or tag.

"I'll be damned," Wallace said. "What happened?"

"I hit the dog," Martha said. She was unnerved. "I killed it, didn't I?"

"It's not dead yet," Wallace said. His heart began to swell into his throat and choke him. The dog whined and flinched. "We should get it to someone who can fix it."

Wallace pulled his shoelace out of the eyes of his right Reebok. He tied the dirty lace around the dog's muzzle.

Wallace awoke with the CEO kneeling over him. He felt queasy and almost gagged at the overbearing smell of dead whales the CEO was drenched in.

"Looks like he got you, too," the CEO said.

"Who?" Wallace pushed himself up on the palms of his hands.

"That loose cannon co-worker of yours. We've taken care of him. There's no need to file a lawsuit. As I told Parks, it would be a blemish on this company. We've got stockholders to worry about. Okay. You're free to see a doctor, on us of course."

"You fired Deeder?"

"Terminated. Yes, of course."

"No, sir, it's not his fault. See . . ."

"No use. My mind's now closed on the matter. No violence allowed in this company. Not acceptable. You've got the rest of the day off as long as you see a doctor. Go on now."

The bleary figure of the CEO straightened his tie and scuttled off. Wallace swallowed some aspirin at the drinking fountain.

Wallace drove by Martha's sister's place, but her Toyota wasn't in the driveway. His favorite radio station was lodged in a sappy dedication loop and Wallace, enraged, contemplated pulling the radio out and backing over it a few times. He switched it off.

At the doctor's office, Wallace waited over an hour. He flipped through several pamphlets on liver disease, lung disease, new age cancer treatment, and sexually transmitted diseases while the doctor struggled to fit him in. The receptionist was friendly with him and for a moment Wallace misconstrued it as a pass. Her lips were wet and glazed. He felt depressed that he would see the receptionist in such a manner. These things kept happening, forcing him into these uncomfortable circumstances, he noted, wallowing in the gloom of the hard truth.

The doctor prescribed Klonopin. He told Wallace that he had heightened anxiety and asked if depression was in the family. He told Wallace not to be ashamed, that it was a chemical problem in his brain. He handed Wallace a scribbled prescription.

Comics were bent over a wire rack inside the pharmacy. Wallace busied himself with them while he waited. The pharmacist had a sliver of spinach lodged between his teeth and when the pharmacist looked at him, Wallace put his head down like an ashamed disciplined child, his chin stubble scratched into his chest. Blood rushed in his head. He felt his heart pound between his temples.

Wallace imagined all the dark secrets this spinach-eating pharmacist was let in on by the nature of his job. He knew whenever someone had hemorrhoids. He knew who had genital herpes. He knew which women were having responsible sex. He probably surmised Wallace was depressed, instead of

being a victim of panic attacks, Wallace thought.

"Shouldn't mix these with alcohol. You don't operate heavy machinery, now do you?" the pharmacist said, clearing his throat. Wallace's face warmed. He wondered why people go to the same pharmacist. Was it that they only wanted one to know their secrets? Or should they run off as soon as conversation is awkward, as soon as a look is questionable, as soon as it seems secrets will be used as leverage?

Deeder's doorbell chimed seven melancholy notes. Deeder yelled from some deep cavern within the house. Wallace rang again. A jeep, parked in the

driveway, had dry mud and sediment caked in its tire wells. Deeder's yelling sounded closer. He said, "Answer the damn door!" Wallace rang again. "Damn it!" Deeder said. After a lumbering series of thuds, the curtains parted in the window revealing Deeder's scowling mug. A lock unlatched and there was Deeder in a camouflage Army shirt and khaki shorts. His expression was intense at first, like there were engineers in the kitchen still harassing him, but he soon mellowed.

"Hey, you made it. Show's about to begin," he said, composing himself.

Off to the left Bobby sat stiff in an armchair beside a slide projector.

"What's with you? Why didn't you get the damn door?" Deeder asked him.

Bobby looked over at Wallace and then went back inspecting slides in the light of a china lamp.

***"Shouldn't mix
these with alcohol.
You don't operate
heavy machinery,
now do you?" the
pharmacist said,
clearing his throat.***

building in the village, though not large at all compared to the whole cavern in which the village was situated. Still, it gave her a feeling of bigness that nothing in the rough-hewn village could. Its angular sides bent into strangely curvaceous peaks. A seemingly misplaced wooden roof topped the whole thing, chapel, narthex; and part of the entryway too.

The work she had was simple, dreary, and relaxing. Oolee ducked into a room off the narthex and found the pickaxe leaning on one of the many beams that held up the wooden roof. The walls here were made of rich brown soil. The chamber had been cut out of the soil in just the last few years, Oolee knew. It was one of the sources for peat, which the villagers mixed with goat fat for fuel. She lelled the axe and began chopping, making bricks just big enough for her to lift three at a time.

As she was cutting, she heard the mewling of the kitten coming from the chapel. She leaned her weight against the chamber's heavy door to let her pet—maybe her only friend—in. She sat down with the cat and pet its hairless skin. Its skin felt loose, unlike the taut skin of the children. She let it down and continued chopping. The cat crouched and leapt up to a rafter, where it remained while Oolee worked.

* * *

Oolee floated through the chapel, woozy, head filled with peat smoke. She felt old, like the logs of the stair, binding fast with the earth. From the top of the chapel—a vantage only dreams could secure—she could see all the villagers from Goatwood and the deep, gathered for the Coming of Dawn ceremony. She dusted cobwebs from her hair, noticing a crack in the ceiling through which an ugly grayish light shone. She pushed away from the domed vault, gliding slowly at first towards the parishioners. The small children in front of the altar noticed her first. They laughed at the falling girl carelessly, like nobody should laugh at anybody. Then the elders looked up, their eyes fettered by pasty cataracts. They stared unseeing—or maybe noticing the crack in the roof. Panic set in among the crowd and in Oolee's chest. She gained speed, careening. The pews offered up jagged corners, decorated with pinnacles and wooden roses.

Oolee flailed at the air, trying to grab handfuls of smoke, falling but trying to tear her way back to the glossy, red ceiling. The air seemed to thin, like an overstretched safety net ripping underneath her. She grabbed the skin of her chest. She tried to brace a body that knew it was going to break.

Her dreams suddenly burst around her, giving way to awareness and discomfort—not fear and violent death, merely aching, cramped discomfort. Oolee's foot scraped along the joist, picking up little globs of tar. She rubbed the fur stubbles of her brow. She gasped a quick yawn, shook her head. The air had the familiar peaty must of the temple storeroom. She disentangled herself from a tortured sleeping position in the crux of the chapel's huge supporting timber.

Stretching, twisting, she leaned back and let her limbs dangle loose in cool air.

Oolee looked around to see if her kitten was still with her. The kitten normally gave her company when duty kept her away from the other villagers. After a time, she rolled and dropped to the floor. Her feet impacted with a cold slap. The wear-polished boards felt like skin. The major and minor joists towered overhead, buttressing the all-important shade roof. The cat was not here.

She wondered how long she'd slept. Occasionally, when cutting bricks for fuel became exceptionally boring, Oolee would sneak such a nap, knowing the priest rarely came to check on her. She felt rested and calm despite—or maybe because of—the nightmare.

She put her weight on the door. A warm draft brushed her straining calves. She swung the door open and screamed in the streaming light.

"Father." She threw her body away from the door, trying to hide herself. "Mercy, mercy, mercy," whispered Oolee helplessly. "Help me," she shouted, "I'm in the storeroom."

The door swung shut again, but shafts of burning light still pierced the shade. It was hinged halfway up its length, designed to act as a slide for the bricks of fuel peat, so even though it was barely ajar it was traced, top and bottom, in the horrible light of Heaven.

"Oolee?" Knocking came from below the floor.

"Priest, it's the day."

"I know, dear. You shouldn't be in the storeroom now. You fell asleep in there again." Oolee was surprised the priest had known before and not spoken of it. She didn't answer. "There's no way out of the storeroom but through the narthex."

"Can you see the face of God?" asked the priest.

"No. But, He's here."

"Is there something you could cover with?"

"No."

"There must be something. If not, then the day will simply have to be countenanced until God's sight dims."

"I can't. The light is all over." The floor was specked with brightness. Oolee was afraid that it might even be shining on her body. The thought made her quiver.

"Strength, Oolee. Oooloolee. Ooolooooooleeeeeeee," he sung her name like a hymn. "Calm yourself and strength will bring you through. Be still. Look over your body, but be still. Is there light on your body?"

She glanced down, barely seeing over her shoulder. Her back arched, and she could see her shoulderblade sticking out, occluding a large swath of skin. "I don't think there's any light on my body."

"Good. Remember, if you cannot see the face of God, then He cannot see you. But stay out of the light. Even His presence will enkindle a sinner's flesh."

enough for you to be born. Now you defy me just like your father did."

Oolee faltered, tears wetting her eyes. *It can't be true*, she thought.

"Your mother died right out there, under the eye of the Angry God. Right where the children of a dozen pious mothers are becoming adults as we speak. Go to the surface if you like. Or better, stand in the light of God for all to see. Set an example for any other would-be heretics. Do what you want. I am done with you. And I have a ceremony to perform."

He pulled a robe over his head and left her, pushing his pompous way through the crowd and leaving the door to swing shut with a slam. Oolee collapsed against the peat bricks, still a jumble from when she dug for the wet and tattered robe. The hairless kitten mewed at her, rubbing its face against her side. She swatted it away. She had to will herself not to throw the poor thing across the room.

Oolee looked up, as if to address God. *It was not true. The priest was a liar*, she told herself. She knew it wasn't true. The light of God would kill nobody. She'd seen that for herself. She wished she could see that light through the ceiling now. Through flowing tears, she saw that the draperies that shielded the storeroom from the light were connected through high-up holes in the wall to those that shielded the chapel.

She swung herself up onto the main joist, thinking she might be able to reach the ties, but only failed in this, too. Though it thrust diagonally, impaling the wall, the joist was too steep to climb. Maybe the axe? No, the axe wouldn't be long enough.

Still, she lowered herself to the ground and picked up the axe. Its sharp head would crush the priest's bald skull if he came in here to execute a heresy sentence upon her. She hefted it and took some swings at the air. She jumped, swinging at the curtain ties. She wanted to bring the draperies down; to show everyone the Light of the Angry God was nothing to fear, to expose the stupidity to everybody; especially God.

Most of all though, she wanted to escape. With a wild yell, Oolee smashed a hole in the low end of the ceiling. A tiny ray of light entered the dark room. She swung hard, enlarging the hole first to the size of a fist, then to a gaping maw.

The door swung open with a screech, letting more light pour in, bringing with it more people. They surrounded her, but stood by, stupefied. Oolee had enlarged the hole wide enough to crawl through. She would escape. She would go into the arms of the Angry God. She would show the village, she thought. Oolee huffed and took a swing at the main joist.

"There's nothing to fear," she said to those near enough to hear her quiet voice. Two or three swings later and she would bring the whole roof down on them.

"Kill the goat girl!" shouted a child's voice.

The crowd pressed forward, throwing her to the floor. She flailed the axe at random, but didn't have enough room to swing. Then, somebody pulled it from her hands. It

seemed the whole village was upon her now. She was in the sun, under the hole in the ceiling.

"Look," she cried, "Look. The light." Though people were already standing in the light, under the vision of the Angry God, nobody seemed to care.

Her shouts were drowned by a chant of, "Kill her, kill her..."

An adult hefted the axe and looked at Oolee with confused eyes. She just sneered.

"Stop."

The priest cleared a path to Oolee. He grabbed her by the arm, ripped her gown from her. "You have never become an adult. You will never be an adult, Oolee. You may not wear the costume of adulthood." With nowhere else to throw it, he sent the tunic sailing to the crowd. Oolee stood naked.

"Oolee must be punished. But we will not kill her. Heretics will suffer the wrath of the Angry God."

The priest lifted Oolee up by the arm, and others joined, pushing her body through the jagged hole she pummeled. Her hair was pulled, her skin scraped, but the pain was only a mild distraction from the overpowering sunlight that surrounded her. Oolee's eyes burned. The noise of the crowd pinched-out almost instantly. She felt her body fall and strike hard soil. She felt heat on her back like a gigantic warm hand.

Oolee only remained splayed out on the ground for an instant. Then, she stood and staggered ahead. The ground was covered with sharp things that poked into her tough calluses. Through squinted eyes, she scanned the washed-out greens and blues of an Upland world as beautiful as she never could have imagined.

A dusty incline sloped down to leafy greenery. There were wide, regular paths that seemed to be made of pitch, crisscrossed in cracks, bearing little plants here and there. The light was hot, but there was what looked to be water down below. As she walked on the jagged pediment, her skin began to prickle. Her hairs stood on end.

There were houses that looked like they'd been empty for eternity, clustered around a large, ovoid pool of water. It was so very hot, and little beads of moisture appeared on her brow. Her skin was crying. She had never experienced anything like it. Where was her father?-her mother? Oolee scratched her shoulders, and where she scratched, it burned.

As she hiked downhill, her skin began to burn more and more. It became nettlesome, annoying. Soon, it became a fire all over her back. She hiked, weeping towards the houses, but distances were deceiving out here. She couldn't tell how far was left to go. There was no shade between herself and the pond. Her skin seared with pain. She could hardly breathe, hardly walk. She reached up and touched the crown of her head. It was blistered. So was the back of her neck.

Maybe she could go back, ask for forgiveness from the villagers. She turned around to see how far it was back. She had come a long way, maybe as long as the great staircase in

When the drumbeat faded and the procession siphoned away all the villagers, local and deep, following the peat smoke up through the fissures into the temple-leaving the village empty-Oolee let her quiet weeping grow into a moaning wail, petering out like the braying of a goat. She stared into the eyes of one of the yeanlings, wishing she really were one of them, unthinking and unfeeling, or at least without need for the likes of priests and villagers. She had been stupid, so stupid she'd almost dared to imagine she might have a future. No, her life was a sealed scroll, like her father before her, and her mother before that. Nobody, not even father discussed Oolee's mother. Instead, he hushed Oolee the few times she brought up the question. It was like her life was one big secret.

Now she saw it all. Her father had escaped the village, probably in search of a mother that escaped to the Uplands before him. Oolee looked at her own flesh. Her hair was pale yellow-white, barely visible. She had been left behind because she didn't have enough goat in her to survive.

No, Oolee thought. Her mother must have been hairless or she would have inherited a double dose of goat. And if her mother wasn't goaty, then...

Oolee was ready to accept the truth. The priest was a liar or a fool. She already knew it was true of the rest of the village. Now, it was obvious that the whole of Goatwood and the whole of all of the deep villages was an enormous flock of imbeciles led by one huge imbecile, fat like a gimp cat, white like ice. But, why had Oolee been left behind? Why, if anybody could defy the will of the Angry God, why didn't father take her too? It was a question she'd articulated immaturely all her life. Now, it was time to answer it.

* * *

She'd intentionally ripped her costume when she'd hung it up—did she really think the priest would care?—but it was intact enough to wear. The climb to the top of the village was short work, even for her long-exercized legs.

Oolee wasn't sure how she intended to exit to the Uplands, but she was driven enough to blind herself to the future. All was uncertainty beyond a few heartbeats time. She concentrated on her footsteps, foot in line with foot. She eschewed the dance of the madman. Stupidity. No, madness. She walked straight and certain.

Any route she might take out would take her past the chapel, and she couldn't divorce herself from curiosity. She entered the narthex. It was packed except for a wide, clear path to the altar. Drums gave heartbeat to the ceremony. Slinking up behind the crowd, she wasn't noticed by anyone. All eyes were on the front.

The Coming of Dawn was the only ceremony that took place during the light hours. Normally, cracks in the roof would have rendered this room uninhabitable during the day,

crisscrossed with bands of light descending through cracked timbers, nevermind the fact that everybody was too scared to test God's will; too blinded by faith to find out whether their convictions had any base. Now, the slanted wooden roof was covered by goatfur cloth. All, except for one circular hole. The thick tube of light struck the shiny tile before the altar.

The drumbeat intensified, heralding a march of children-cum-adults. They strode confidently up the aisle. Each one carried a wide basket, held out like an offering. They balanced the baskets upon their heads as they walked, one by one taking the leaf's path under the eye of God. Oolee had completed her rite of passage already, she realized, when she traversed the narthex, going a hundred times farther and with a hundred times more useless fear. She was happy to have been excluded from this farce.

After the procession snaked its way through the temple, the crowd fell in, enclosing the aisle, leaving room for Oolee to sneak into the storeroom on the side. Her eyes, having gotten used to the unusual brightness in the chapel, didn't see the priest before her ears heard his startled snort.

"What are you doing here? I told you to stay in the village center."

"I don't care what you tell me anymore," she said. He gasped, but waited as though anticipating more explanation. Oolee obliged, "I'm going to the Uplands to find my father."

Oolee's sight was still painted with translucent colors, but she could tell his facial expression was going through contortions.

"Is that what you think happened? Do you think your father went away voluntarily?" He

chortled, then stopped himself, "Oolee, your father was banished."

"Banished to the Uplands?"

"No Oolee, your father was banished to the depths. He was always a heretic, but I gave him the benefit of the doubt because I wanted you to be raised by an adult, just like I gave you the benefit of the doubt while you were still in the womb. I postponed the execution of your heretic mother long



parentless children anyway. The other local children were more difficult to avoid. The boys were testing their guile with girls from the deep, and the local girls formed little parades up and down the staircase, breaking up and coalescing again like the random wanderings of a herd of loose goats. She had seen it year after year, every time dawn came and people prepared for the Test of the Eye, where the children became adults. Now, it was her turn and she wandered alone.

She traversed the paths and corridors of the village, completing a huge, meandering circuit. Everywhere, there were people. Returning to the village center, she heard a woman's voice call out, "Oolee. Ooolooloollee..."

A woman she recognized peeked out over a wall across the street from her father's old house. "Oolee, you're going to come of age so nicely. You must've worked hard on that outfit. Why aren't you joining the processions?"

"I don't really have anybody to go with."

The woman pursed her lips and nodded, seeming to understand. Oolee had passed this place hundreds of times—the woman lived there as long as she could remember, since before her father went away—yet this was the first time she had spoken more than five words to her.

"Maybe we can help each other. If you were to take over my stand for a while, I could get more pickling spice and you could have a chance to show off to the boys from the deep villages. We've had such a busy day, even for Celebration time, you know. I just have to run up the stair a couple of landings for more catgut." The woman smiled warmly, "I trust you know the value of goatskin footings?"

* * *

Time sped and Oolee had only made one trade—two pots of pickled mushrooms for a pair of footings—before the woman returned. Oolee continued bartering while the woman sewed pitch between multiple layers of leather to form resilient soles. Patrons came in waves, charmed to do business with a local girl. They were surprised by Oolee's sense of duty, choosing to stay here and help out her mother while the other girls flaunted their own wares before jeering adolescent boys. "Are you already betrothed?" asked one older gentleman before hinting that his son would do good to find such an independent woman. She smiled inwardly. The thought of leaving the village with a boy from the deep appealed to her more than she would have expected. Coming of age was full of surprises. Maybe, just maybe...she thought. Regardless of the outcome of the day, it was glorious to be spared the perpetual taunting she had endured all her life.

One of the local boys led a group of children, mostly girls, down the little street, playing tour guide. "Here we have my own home." It was the tall mud-flinging boy. "This is one of the best stands in Goatwood village. Better than anything you'll find at the bazaar proper."

The other children were enthralled. They pressed their hands against all the wares, touching, stroking, covertly pocketing. Oolee pretended not to notice. One of the boys eyed Oolee, taking her passivity as silent approval of the thievery. He grabbed fat handfuls of footing, stuffing them under a fluffy white linen celebration outfit. She remained rock solid, head down.

"Hey you, give me some of those pickles there." The boy commanded Oolee like a servant. He seemed full of his own power, as if he were priest of his own little flock of children. "Hey, do you hear me?"

Oolee turned without lifting her face to the boy. The mushrooms were on an upper shelf, where she'd been asked to place them. She started to reach up, but found she couldn't do it without straining her neck. Even though she looked away, her face might get betrayed to the boy or, worse, she might lose her headdress. As quick as she could, she pulled the earthenware pot down and spun round, offering it forth with both hands. Just as she faced the boy, he reached out a long arm and knocked the headdress to the filthy cave floor.

"I thought that was you. Ladies and gentlemen," he turned to address the boys and girls from the deep, "meet Goatwood's own Goat Girl."

All the children started laughing, but stopped abruptly. The woman who ran the stand was standing with one hand on her hip and the other squeezing deeply into the flesh of a terrified thief. "Oolee. By the Angry God, pay attention. This boy almost got away with a whole bolt of my best cloth."

The woman rang a huge bell that hung near the shelves. A head—the woman's husband's—stuck out an upper story window. "Get the priest, dear. I've got some trouble here."

* * *

"I notice you slept with the goats again," began the priest.

Seeing an advantage, the thief from the deep interjected "She told me I could take them."

"I will be talking to your parents, boy. Now, go. You may have to abstain from the Coming of Dawn ceremony." He gestured for the boy to leave through the front door, which he did, head hung low. "As for you Oolee, it is certain that you cannot be trusted to act appropriately. Take your headdress and tunic and put them back in the alcove."

Unable to speak, and uncertain whether to lie or tell the truth in her defense, Oolee just shook her head in disbelief. She could only make incoherent plaintive noises.

"It's almost time for the Coming of Dawn ceremony. Now, come with me children. Oolee, go and do as I say and sleep out the rest of the day with your goats."

* * *

foot slid, her hands went out, incised by a sharp corner of flooring. Oolee let out a yelp and ended up flat. On her belly, cheek against the warm floor, her body exposed. She froze, expecting instant death, squeezing her eyes so tight that the muscles of her forehead trembled.

Be strong. the voice was quiet in her head. She tried to imagine what the priest would advise now, but no soothing words or stern pronouncements presented themselves. *Be strong.* She wished there was more, but those were the only words she had. She wanted to ask him. "How? How can I be strong against the wrath of the Angry God?"

She didn't know whether to get up and run, or to stare up into the face of God and take her punishment without fear. She tried picturing the priest in this situation, splayed out on the chapel floor. The scene of his huge bulk flailing in terror would have thrown her into fits of laughter, if she weren't afraid for her own life.

Oolee stood up. She pulled the robe back on, not bothering to make sure it was secure or concealing. She remembered her father's stories. As a young girl, she had been shocked that anybody had ever gone above the chapel. Even the idea of anything up there was terribly confusing. Her father described the Uplands like an infinite playground. She had never asked him what God had said. She imagined the face of the Angry God smiling on her father and his friends. He was special. She was special too.

It was the first time she believed those words, though her father had told her over and again. The Angry God had allowed her nakedness before him. Truly, she was untainted by the sin of humanity. Perhaps years of being ostracized was enough punishment for one girl. Truly, she was special. Even the priest occasionally sounded reverent when he admonished her for being ashamed of her fur. Of course, she wasn't truly naked. She walked the last distance across the narthex in a straight line, fearless.

* * *

"You indolent girl. Do you know you could have brought the wrath of God down on us all? What were you doing in the chapel during the light hours anyway?"

"I thought the light didn't come until the ceremony started, so I just..."

"The light of God didn't shine straight on you, did it? No, of course not. Now surely you would be dead if that were so. You must never enter the light of the Angry God again. Never."

She wanted to ask him if it was really true, what her father had told her, that humans could go to the Aboveland, at least those with the goat in them, but she didn't interrupt the priest's tirade. Besides, it was blasphemous to even think a human might enter Heaven.

"The tiniest little hint that we're down here and you'll be the doom of the whole village. Our God is a furious god. You go and study now."

The cat skinked near the fissure entrance, avoiding the smoke. Oolee picked it up and dropped it again and descended the stairs, with no intent of studying. Instead, she found a corner of the goat pens where she could sit and ponder.

* * *

Oolee faded in and out of sleep, resting on a nanny goat's heaving ribcage. The goats' fur was soft, unlike anything else she'd known in her life. Moss was soft, but wet and scratchy, and even the robes weaved of goat fur were scratchy and lacked the sheen of the goats' bodies.

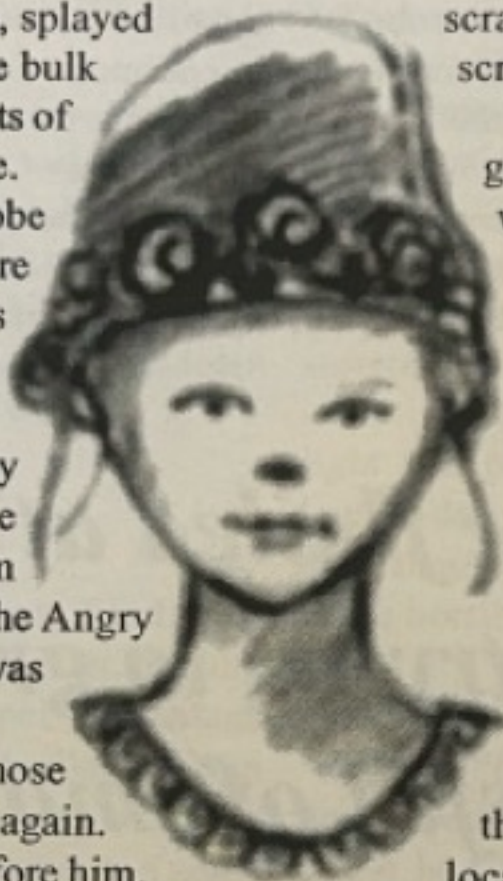
The only thing that reminded her of the goat hair was her father's furry head. Her own hair was so thin and short that she couldn't run her fingers through it. She remembered playing with her father's hair while he slept. She dug her fingers in the goat's fur and missed the strong arms of her father, of which the goats were no simulacrum.

* * *

Oolee was roused by a noisy crowd. She pulled herself up to look over the fence. Goatwood was awash with people from the deep villages. They bantered with the locals, and traded their tools and food for goat products and other local specialties. The bartering was vigorous, but polite. Deep villagers seemed to treat those of Goatwood like benevolent masters, and the Goatwood villagers seemed to take it for granted. Maybe it would have been reversed if it was the high villagers who descended into the depth of the earth for all the major celebrations, or maybe it was just their proximity to the light of God that gave them a special relevance.

Children were frocked in festive tunics that draped the ground, some made of pelts, others decorative parchment. Oolee raced for the village center, where her own celebratory clothing was hanging in the priest's alcove. The priest was out, so Oolee pulled them off their hook and donned them on her own. The outfit was light and delicate; she had worked with the pale brown parchment for months, embossing it with gold and green, sometimes getting patches stuck to her fingers by the seaming pitch and having to start again. The tunic had a high neck, long sleeves and its bottom brushed her foot tops, the goat fur trim tickling. On her head, she carefully placed a headdress made from woven strips of fine cat leather, hardened into loops that traced Oolee's forehead, neck, and ears. The costume left no hair exposed.

In opulence, Oolee walked the village among newcomers, finding it easy to avoid the gaze of locals. Most were engaged in transactions, too busy to bother with



Oolee slowly uncurled and stood in the corner like a cat on a fencepost, eyes darting about in search of some escape from her little piece of firmament in the suddenly-roiling current of light. Dust motes swirled and dodged like aggravated gnats. It was like her father had told her, everything took on a new liveliness in the Light of God. The air seemed to breathe itself in. Oolee's eyes had trouble seeing anything but the rays of light that impaled her workspace.

She squinted at the earthen walls, the pitchy timbers, the wheelbarrow full of peat bricks, and the stacked bricks along the wall to her side.

"There's a robe; an old robe under the fuel bricks."

"Knock them over. Just get the robe. Even if you have to expose yourself to the light to do it. Get the robe."

She attacked the pile she'd carefully stacked over the last weeks. The falling bricks further dusted the already turbid air. She tore down to the soggy bottom.

Under the fuel stack, was fabric. She remembered putting it there at the priest's request in order to shield the floor from the acid bite of the humus. The robe was purple, fading at the edges to the ruddy gray of dried blood. Its weave, once fine, had suffered terribly in its defense of the floorboards. Oolee wondered if it was even wearable.

Though it bore tremendous gashes, the size of the robe, doubled over several times, ensured Oolee's little body complete coverage. "I'm putting the robe on. I think it will work."

"Go, Oolee. Cover up, and go."

"I'm afraid." The robe dripped moist stench.

"Move like a falling leaf, dear. Take as many steps as you can. The narthex is big and you are small."

Oolee threw herself through the complaining hatch, the priest's disembodied voice shouting "Be strong," now drowning out in the wood-against-wood squeal of the ancient narthex door. The chamber's walls were stone, but they were smooth as skin-furless skin. These walls had been hewn from the same stone as the caverns where the village nestled. These walls were made so long ago that it made her think of the priest, the elders, and even the buildings of the village itself as newborns, fresh to the world.

She took a few steps to the left, backed up a step, danced to the right, then paused. She resisted the urge to bolt for the other side. That would be lunatic. She'd be seen, she knew, if she tried it. No, her escape must be a meandering one. Trying to blend into the woodwork, keeping her grimy mantle tight around her body, pinned with both hands to her chest,

Oolee danced a sharply punctuated set of minuets through the sun-filled space of the narthex. Like a leaf.

She looked only towards her feet, there was so much light her eyes stung. She had never seen anything like it. Not staring into a heating fire or a lighting one, not even in the dazzling glow of the flickermoths at the reflection pool deep under Goatwood village's corridors. Not ever. The narthex was totally alien to her now. She was awash in the wrath of the Angry God, trying hard to keep her movements natural and random. But her legs felt soft and weak as moss. She voiced the priest's words from memory, trying to make them a shield. Be strong.

She tried to picture him at the altar, reading from sacred texts carved in stone. His massive pallidness that excised an enormous shadow in the fire-lit chapel. Surely he could hide Oolee from the face of God. Yet, he was below, down in the caverns.

The only way to fool God was the Dance of the Madman, the Dance of the Falling Leaf. She placed her feet at ridiculous angles, taking random strides, slow and erratic, to ensure that from above, God's reckoning would not see in her motions the telltale efficiency of a human.

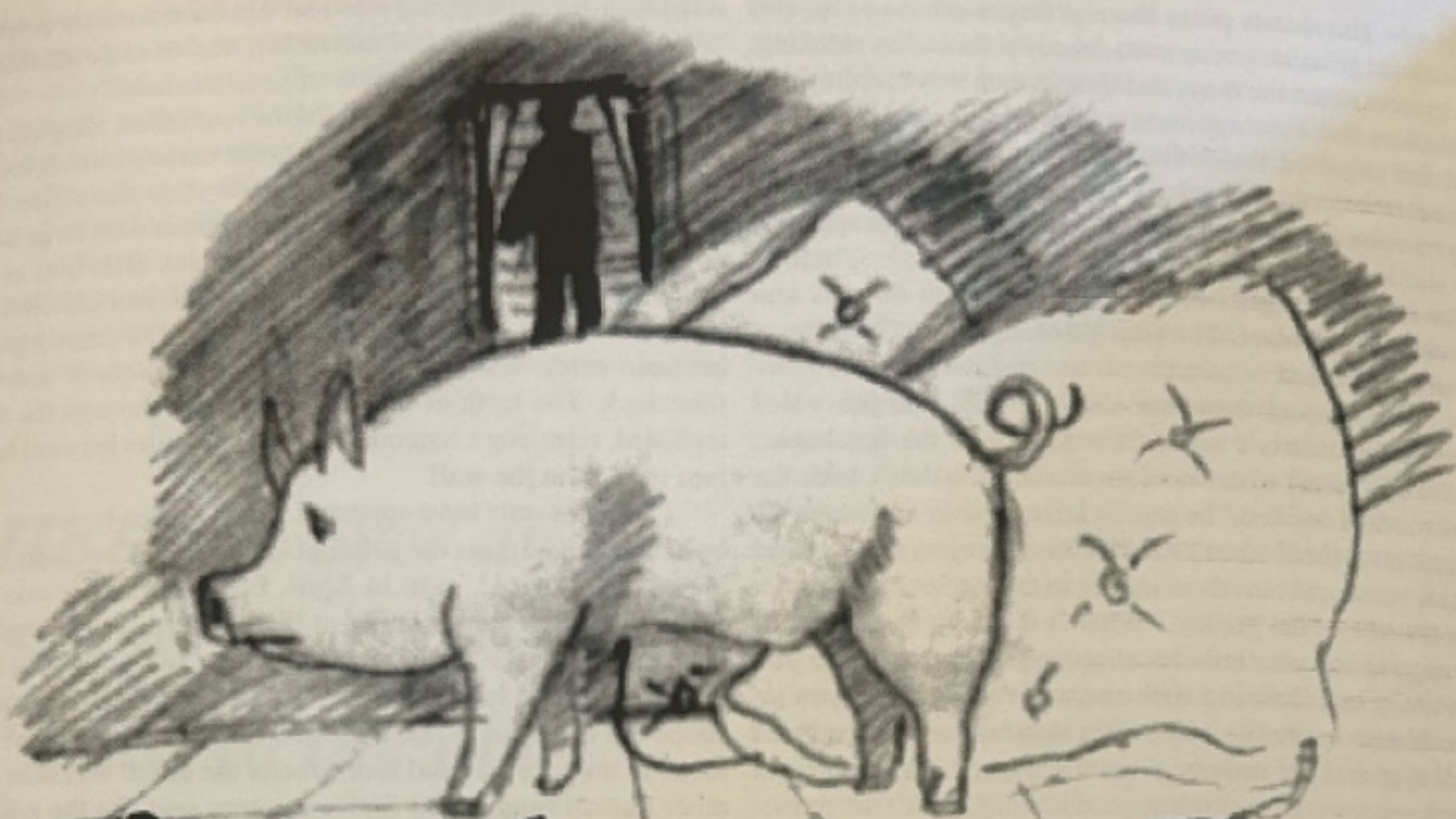
Cursed beings, they all were, she had known it from a thousand sermons' exhortations. Yet, it was never clear to her what they had done to deserve banishment from the Aboveground, the Uplands, Heaven. *Sins against God* were the words of the priest.

Unnamed sins from a thousand generations ago were the words her father had once hissed in her ear while the priest admonished his flock never to forget their God-fearing nature.

But once, they'd walked on the Aboveground and danced in celebration. She didn't know how much of the Faith to believe, but even her father accepted those basic truths. When she was a child, her father made bedtime stories out of what he claimed were real occurrences from his own childhood. Stories about villagers who could skirt the eyes of God. Others who, like him, had some of the goat in them. She knew it was an impiety. More than an impiety, it was a blasphemous affront—but it assuaged some of the fear.

She continued her dance, now more than three quarters of the way across the vast and empty narthex. Here, the floor became uneven. A fissure broke the walls nearby and tiles tilted at subtly incorrect angles. She concentrated on her feet, placing each one square in the middle of a tile, and avoiding the broken tiles. Her makeshift body-covering tugged a little on her shoulder. As she took a large stride across several fragmented tiles, she was jerked back, and missed a step. Her

Oolee flailed at the air, trying to grab handful of smoke...



The Money Pig

Joe Bellomy

"Respect the pig," father began as always, hands clasped together, head slightly bowed. "We, unlike other creeds, know from whence our bounty flows. Respect the pig, our sacred heart, our life, our joy. Amen."

The pig was kept in the basement where they washed it and fed it according to its pleasure. It was average pig I suppose. Some families had more robust, more capable and more productive pigs. Ours, well, it was adequate.

The pig ate money. And not just any money. It had no taste for money that was not seasoned with sweat and sacrifice. It snorted at windfalls and cash gifts. It was a fairly picky pig. But in return for its feeding the pig provided. Yes, the pig provided.

The first time I actually saw the pig was when grandmother died. Mother held my hand and we went to petition the pig of some assistance.

Mom had a few notes she managed to wrestle from Lady Bee downtown in exchange for some housecleaning. She offered them up to the pig and I watched amazed as it devoured them. As it did so its skin glowed a bright pink. Then she rubbed its belly and prayed that it provide a coffin for her

poor departed mother. No sooner had she finished when a knock came at the door and old Mr. Cally appeared with an offer to construct a coffin free of charge as a gift to our family.

So it went. The pig worked in mysterious ways.

Yet there was something horrific about watching the pig eat hard earned money. It would stare at you as it munched, watching as if it knew exactly what you were thinking. And in my case perhaps it did.

I'm not an evil man. Though now, out here by the fire, there's a certain joy I've experienced of late. It's a mischievous satisfaction with myself I guess.

The pig had held the place of honor in the family. It got the best bedding, the warmest room, and the best entertainment. They even put on shows for the damn thing. The most excessive attention and caring was lavished on the pig. It was bathed daily, powdered, oiled, massaged, all this even as it was worshipped...and feared.

Oh yes, they were terrified by the pig, and rightly so... the pig had a cruel streak. On many occasions after feeding and prayers the pig would wallow and glow and finally produce nothing more than a nasty belch. The family always blamed itself. As if somehow they had not taking proper care of it or

The orderly peers down at Raymond over wire-rim glasses and grins, his young teeth already yellowed by smoking. He glances about the room and the old man's eyes follow his to the bars that have appeared on the windows, the padding that has engulfed the walls. These things were not there moments before, the orderly put them there, or perhaps Raymond brought them himself. He tilts his head, listening to the shiftless whining of the other drooling fools. There is terror in the old man's eyes. The shimmering doctors and ghostlike nurses leave. The young orderly stays, hovering at the edge of the bed.

Raymond mumbles incoherently, and his voice becomes the orderly's voice. "Couldn't take the loneliness, pops?" the young man wonders aloud. "Couldn't take the loneliness and cracked," he says as he leans over and snaps his fingers next to the old man's ear. His young fingers wrap around the pale wrists and bind them tightly in the leather cuffs grown from the side of the gurney. "What is it like to be old? Your skin sagging and your muscles atrophied? How long have you been sitting in a chair in a dark corner? You look like you've been old your entire life." The tears stand out in the damaged man's eyes and the orderly screws a wicked smile onto his face.

The orderly walks slowly across the room, gazes out the window and shakes his head. "What does it feel like to be a wrinkled nobody? Do you have memories? Do they mean anything?" The orderly walks back to the gurney and grips the metal bars tightly. His knuckles turn white. "My memory is thin, there is only the now for me, only this moment. That's youth, you see, to live in this moment, because this is the only moment that ever is."

The Möbius strip is turning in Raymond's mind. He mumbles and his ears hear the orderly's voice again. "I'll forget you the moment I leave this room, do you understand?" The orderly grasps Raymond's left foot and a wave of pain numbs everything for a moment. The figure grinning at him shimmers, the whole room shimmers, and then the pain subsides. It leaves him weak, incompetent, his mind twisting on itself in paradoxical loops. The orderly becomes solid again,

it is like a figure stepping into real life from a movie screen. "And you will lie here and remember, unable to do anything, trapped in this bed for the rest of your memory."

The orderly steps out of the room then, flipping the light switch as he goes. He returns to the nurse's station, looks at the clock, and walks down the hallway to the office. He shoulders past a frazzled, gray-haired woman with large bags under her eyes. She turns around and stares after him as he walks into the office. She makes no sound, just clutches an aged, featureless stuffed animal close to her. The orderly grabs his time card, "Edward R. Oberson," and slides it into the timeclock. The teeth of the machine punch through the thin tagboard, releasing a tenuous thud, and he slides his card back into its slot on the wall.

The stars have appeared already when he leaves the building, and he pulls the collar of his leather jacket high. The nights are still cold, even in April. Edward walks across the parking lot and waits silently at the graffiti-laden fiberglass bus stop. Soon the blue and chrome city bus pulls to a halt next to him and he steps aboard. Already, he has forgotten about the old man in the hospital. What was his name? He looks at the faces around him, smells the sweat and skin and other human smells, and finds an empty seat. As the wheels of the bus turn, they leave behind all his old memories.

Later, Edward lurches drunkenly down a forgotten street. He is laughing and muttering to himself and he weaves up the street, stepping on and off the curb. In one hand is a green bottle nearly empty, the last of twelve. He stops at the top of a hill and lights a cigarette, crumpling and dropping the empty foil pack. He is thinking about the vigor of life, he is excited by it. Suddenly, he swings the bottle around and hurls it at the sidewalk. It collides with the edge of the curb with bitter accuracy, shattering the silence of the night. A small girl awakens and looks out her window. Edward grits his teeth and hurls the pink lighter to the pavement. It ignites with a dull thud much like the time clock that Edward has already forgotten. A gout of flame appears for the briefest moment and then is gone, leaving behind nothing but plastic shards scattered amid the ruins of a green bottle.



so he can see his sole. This causes some bit of discomfort. These muscles have grown weak and thin over years of office chairs and vinyl recliners. He sees the green shard jutting from his foot and wonders where it came from. He looks around, sees the broken beer bottle lying at the curb, the crumpled pack of generic cigarettes, both of these lying amid the plastic ruins of an exploded pink lighter; the ruins of a drunken effigy.

Raymond curses again, not the "fuck" or the "shit the bed" he might have used in his youth, but the rather more refined and bitter "goddamn kids" of impending old age. He looks around again, suddenly afraid of being seen in this

*He leans over and
snaps his fingers
next to the old
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young fingers wrap
around the pale
wrists and bind
them tightly in the
leather cuffs...*

compromising state. A child watches him from her bedroom window across the street, but he does not see this. To him the streets are still empty. She might have called out to her mother, but she fears this old man whose beady eyes and paunchy cheeks wrinkle up in a frown every time he sees her. She clutches her stuffed panda bear and watches, thinking of a dream she had the night before.

The bleeding has begun in earnest now. What started as a tiny rose blossom soon becomes widening streams navigating the wrinkles in his soles. He rolls back to his hands and knees, being careful to keep his left foot held high. He

curses the carelessness of youth again, wondering why kids are such self-absorbed and savage bastards. He never did anything like this in his youth, never drunkenly careened an automobile into a telephone pole, never smashed mailboxes with a Louisville Slugger, never back-talked his mother or father, never wore his hair long, never slapped a pretty girl on the ass, never got into trouble. He had always made his parents proud, his mother had called him a "little adult."

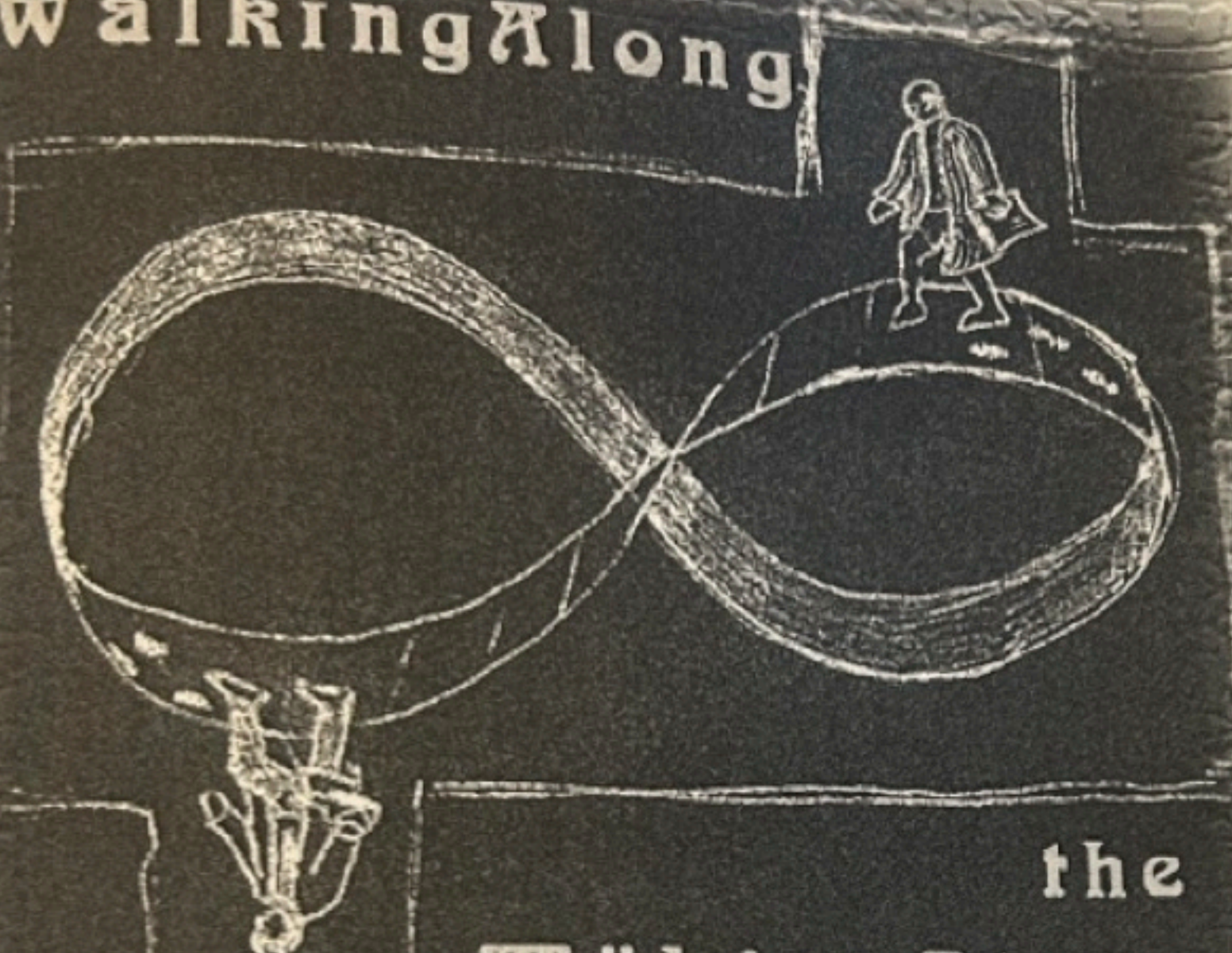
Gritting his teeth, Raymond begins the fifteen-foot ascent up the sidewalk to his apartment building. The distance has become a marathon and the stinging in his knees and hands flashes like a traffic signal. He inches along, spitting out a new vulgarity every foot. He pauses twice to make sure no one is watching. The little girl across the street looks on with tears in her eyes and whispers her dream to her bear. After minutes more like days, he climbs onto the porch. He ignores the trail of blood he has left on the sidewalk, a map of his heart painted onto the concrete.

He carefully rises to one foot. He wobbles on that copascetic knee, fumbling for the keys in his pocket, and a cloud of dizziness engulfs him like a swarm of flies. His left foot automatically steps down to correct his failing balance, jarring the shard against a bone and releasing a burning gout of blood. Sweat breaks out on his forehead and he bites down on his lower lip to withhold a scream. White motes float across his vision. The world goes topsy-turvy as he careens backwards. The back of his head collides with the sidewalk, his yellowed teeth bite through his bottom lip. The last thought he has before blacking out is a bitter one: he left the newspaper lying at the curb.



When Raymond floats into semiconsciousness, he finds himself surrounded by a flurry of spinning white clouds. They are figures in white clothing, and he is lying in a hospital bed, the sheets bleached white. The faces and words are unformed, and he cannot feel his body. He feels the sort of Escher-like lucidity that comes on the very edge of sleep. In this state everything rolls back on itself like a Möbius strip; dreams bleed into reality, the future causes the past, and the dead rise from their graves. He moans. His ears detect this undead sound; it becomes the gibbering of a mad prisoner in the next cell. Fear grips his belly. He looks around wildly. Only one figure remains motionless, its broad shoulders in a crisp hospital uniform. Raymond tries to focus, pick out the details of the liquid face. The face solidifies, takes on the appearance of his father, but younger, more like his brother's face might have been if he had lived to twenty years. The face shifts again, the cheeks rising like tectonic plates and the eyes sinking further in, becoming the face of a nameless bully who had once beat him so badly that he had to skip school for a week to recover. It is the face of a young orderly.

Walking Along



the Möbius Strip

-21-

Shannon Rampe

It is early morning. Dawn has not yet unwrapped the gray fog hanging over the streets like gauze. Raymond rubs the bags under his eyes as he steps onto the front porch of his downtown apartment building; he has not yet had his morning cup of coffee. The concrete chills his bare feet, he is wearing nothing more than a tattered blue bathrobe and underwear with the elastic coming loose. He curses the paperboy under his breath. The little brat has taken to dropping the paper at the curb instead of on the porch steps of the apartment building.

He hurries to the curb, glancing about to make sure no one is watching this flaccid man hobbling about in a bathrobe. The street is mostly empty. Raymond steps off the curb, leans down, and grasps the paper. He scans the headlines as he turns. In the back of his mind he is thinking about the pot of coffee brewing black in his kitchenette, waiting for the

completion of this morning ritual. He is thinking about a stack of insurance claims at the office, the broken fax machine, the new secretary with the red hair and moist lips. The headlines tell of food shortages in Turkey and a long shard of glass slides into his foot.

He does not feel it immediately; his mind is occupied with other matters. It is only when he steps down that he drives the green shard deep into the arch of his foot, slicing through the ghosts of calluses and a network of muscles and tendons. Raymond cries out softly and falls to the sidewalk. His knees and palms strike the pavement, leaving behind a veil of skin and blood. His bathrobe falls open and his pallid flesh is bared to the world.

He rolls over, drops the forgotten newspaper, and pulls his bathrobe over his genitals, staining the blue terrycloth with his bloody hands. He delicately pulls his left foot around

the village. The hill was steep and easy going downwards, but looked impossible upwards.

She fell to her knees, stinging them on the sharp plant leaves that covered the ground here. She forced herself to turn towards the Angry God. His ruddy face filled almost a quarter of the blue and pink domed roof above.

"I didn't mean to be a heretic." She shouted at the Angry God. "Help me," she said as she wept in full view of His face but the light just burned hers. Unable to breath, Oolee slumped in the grass, pain hugging close.

She tried to whisper to whoever could hear, but no sound came out.

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as if somehow they were less deserving than other families whose pigs were producing goodies left and right.

I came to hate the pig slowly, over time. One thing particularly annoyed me. At feeding, as it chewed the families wealth, it would stare blankly at me, a gaze so vacuous and bland it seemed almost blind. It gazed upon me with terrible pink eyes and the superiority of a king, as if waiting for me to supplicate myself before it, as if it were divining my hearts desires and were snatching them and giving them to itself to delve out at its own whim or fancy. There was no definitive the moment when my hatred began but there was a moment of decision..

It was the day mother made me feed the pig and ask for its forgiveness. Oh, the pig was our confessor also. Of course you had to pay for the privilege.

I earned three gold coins that day helping Mr. Toby, the blacksmith, shovel dirt into the back of his wagon. It was hard work and at the end of the day I paused on the way home to buy a snack and something to drink. I lingered too long and was late getting home. Mother was furious. The pig needed attention. It was due a wash and its linens needed changed. When I explained to her that I had earned three gold pieces she demanded I feed them to the pig and ask for its pardon.

I laid the gold in my palm and let the pig eat them one by one. When it had finished it turned promptly as if dismissing me and farted a most noxious stench. Then it waddled back to its silk pillows and rolled over on its back..

It was then the hatred burned in me like a white ember from Mr. Toby's hearth.

It took months of planning and study, but finally the time came. I was nearly a man I had not been given affirmation by the family. But I would affirm it myself. And as the sun set and the nights grew late I meditated on what I would do and how I would do it.

On that night I pulled a butcher knife from the drawer and tested its edge. I took a moment to sharpen it against the grinding stone on the counter. A cold rod of purpose slid up my spine. Long ago they use to castrate the things so they would fatten up before the slaughter. I think I would have enjoyed that. As it was, I would just have to be satisfied with the slaughter alone. And that is what I was determined it would be.

Really there was nothing the pig could produce which we ourselves could not. Convenience perhaps. Feed it a chunk of cash and rub its belly a bit and hopefully it would produce. Good things would come to you. But we worked to feed the pig. In the end we were feeding it our freedom and humanity, our professional choices, our emotional stability and our physical well being. The pig gave us everything and in exchange it took our souls.

But no more.

The steps creaked as I entered the basement. I heard the pig move. It had to sense something was wrong. Rarely did anyone enter the pen at night. I held the knife behind my back and when I reached the bottom of the steps I flicked on the light. I wanted to see this event. The pig observed me nonchalantly, it snorted with disdain as I entered its pen. There was something oppressive about the thing. Here was I, a human being, crown of creation subservient to a pig. I was not even its equal in the family hierarchy. The pig had always taken precedence.

Oh, the pig knew. Somehow it knew. No longer was the look in its eyes one of placid self satisfaction. Now it looked as a pig should when confronted by a man. It squealed slightly and scrambled to the corner of the pen. I entered and locked the gate behind me. I let the knife fall to my side in clear view of the animal. It went wild, squealing and running around the perimeter of the pen, trampling silk cushions and velvet blankets beneath mad scurrying pig feet. I was quick, and with an insane glee, I lunged at the beast and managed to grip one of its hind legs. Then with all of my muscle and determination I jerked the animal onto its back and with a force I had not know myself capable of I bore down on the beast and plunged the blade into its throat. Its squealing immediately transformed into the gurgling spurt of blood and air. I pulled the knife downward and rightly gutted the animal.

There is no sound to the dark wetness of spilled blood.

In moments a ruckus began upstairs and I knew the family would come for me. I knew the consequences would be severe but I had devised a plan of escape.

I stuffed the carcass into a laundry bag and before anyone could invade the basement I slipped out the side door.

As youth and strength and excitement carried me, I moved quickly through the village. I moved through the streets of unlit shops and passed the memorial bronze effigy of the money pig in the center of the square. In short time I found the exterior wall.

I had climbed this wall my entire youth, so even with my added burden it proved none too difficult. Once on the outside I moved quickly into the distance. I felt a strange awkwardness in my face and it took me a moment to realize that it was the result of the widest, maddest, teeth baring smile my features could possibly produce.

The pig was heavy and grew heavier with each step. I don't know why I traveled so far that night as I was sure there would be no one following me. The villagers had long since quit going out into the world and had over time developed a keen sense of fear concerning the wilderness. Generally if their pigs were healthy, they were happy. On the other hand, I could not recall the last time a pig had been murdered. Better safe than sorry I thought.

massive bronze head turned and its metallic eyes peered at me. I heard a scream coming from my own throat.
"Shh... You're hurt badly." The voice was barely audible.

Then before I sunk back into darkness I heard the sound of a lid slipping around the lip of a jar.

Again the voices.

"I think he might have been handsome."
"He's a criminal, Koshka. A murderer, honey."
"What will they do to him?"
"If he lives? That doesn't concern us."
"You're just thinking of the reward."
"Four pigs? Of course I'm thinking of that."
"I wonder why he did it?"
"Who knows why?" the deep voice mumbled.

I felt a cool hand on my forehead. My vision was still blurred but my breathing seemed easier. I tried to talk but could no move my mouth.

"The infection is spreading and he's developing a fever. The maggots have helped a bit."

"Still, the leg is most likely lost."

"Probably."

There was a long pause and again I heard the slow rumble of wooden wheels.

"Did you hear the noise last night?"

"Yes, Koshka."

"It scared me."

"Something is following us."

"But what?"

"Look at him. Something did that. I don't think it's finished with him."

"Then we are in danger too."

"Well, we certainly can't leave him and the reward is well worth a risk."

I could see the hunched back of the old man from where I lie in the back of the wagon. Next to him sat the frail body of a young woman. She turned and looked softly at me.

I woke to a violent jerk of the wagon, frantic movement and hurried whispering.

"Is it out there?" the girl was asking.

"Yes. It's wounded one of the horses."

A spark appeared in the darkness and a flame sprouted from a lamp hanging overhead.

I pushed myself upward to a sitting position. My mind was still groggy and I felt far removed from the moment.

They were rummaging through a large cloth satchel.

The wagon jerked forward. Outside the horses snorted with agitation.

"Where is the pistol?" the old man demanded.

"Grandfather," said the girl. "All the firearms were sold for the move."

The old man sat back. "Ah, yes," he said, nodding to himself.

"How badly is the horse injured?"

"I don't know, they will not move in the darkness. They're spooked."

"Did you see it out there?"

"No, it's too dark."

Again the horses jostled the wagon.

"What are we going to do?"

"We have to drive it off. If it lames a horse we'll be stuck."

I watched as the old man closed his eyes to think. It was very quick. When he opened them again he looked directly at me.

"What's out there?"

I could not respond. My mind had ceased functioning. I could offer nothing but a resigned chuckle.

"He's delirious," the girl said.

"We could set him back on the street where we found him."

"We can't just throw him out."

"Yes, we could. But as soon as it was finished with him we might be next."

"I tried to kill it," I said weakly trying to focus.

The old man shook his head.

He twisted around and opened a box at the side of the wagon. He took out the blade that I had carried.

"Stay here," he ordered. Taking a lamp he went out through the front of the wagon.

"What's he doing?" I asked.

Koshka just shrugged her shoulders. Then a coldness came into her gaze. "If he gets harmed you won't live through the night."

We sat for some time in the darkness I tried to tell her what had happened but could not order my thinking. The horses had quieted and except for the natural sounds of the woods we heard nothing.

I tried to think. I considered my position. I was damned between two fates. Probable death if they left me to the boar or return to the village and my punishment. My condition made me helpless and my fate was entirely in the hands of this old man and young woman. And though it was not simple kindness they had exercised in taking me in nevertheless they had saved my life. My return to the village would give them some reward. More than I myself could offer.

The boar was a different matter. It had its own course of action and that now concerned these people as well as myself.

I had no doubt the beast could lame the horses as they stood tied and even the three of us would pose little threat to the animal. A wave of guilt touched me. These people did not deserve this.

reaching for the knife and landing on my side I got a hold of it. I rolled sideways into the water and came to a rest on my stomach holding the knife out in defense.

The hog though, had not moved. It observed me cautiously and seemed not to consider me a danger.

Slowly it approached. I braced myself for the attack but it never came. The pig's attention was diverted to the coin which still lay on the rock where I had placed it. The pig ignored me the coin commanded its attention. It walked to the rock and with its huge snout examined the gold.

I slipped further back into the water until just my eyes and nose protruded above the surface. Even in my terror the cool water soothed of my wounds.

Suddenly the pig snatched the coin up in its mouth and with a jerk of its head, swallowed the sovereign.

The effect was immediate. The animal grunts quieted. It shivered. Its main smoothed out and seemed to attain an imperceptible luster. Brow and eyes relaxed and it blinked oddly as if the light had become too bright. Then, strangely, it lay down on its side and began to wallow happily in the dirt. I was transfixed by the change in the beast. Eventually it regained its feet and calmly walked to the water's edge not more than a few feet from me. It eyed me as it drank but I could read nothing there. Its gaze was one of simple observation. It drank deeply then ambled some yards away and lay down where it simply went to sleep.

I wasted no time. Tucking the blade in my waist band and regaining the branch I had dropped I limped as quickly as possible away from the area. Even in its present lethargy I had no illusions about defeating the animal. I would make quick my escape and hope my wounds would heal. I wished fervently that I could somehow find my way back to the village.

The next morning I chanced to find a wild bunch of cabbages and another crop of berries. For the first time in weeks I was able to fill my stomach and was free of the gnawing hunger which had plagued me.

The gash around my torso seemed to be healing and the swelling in my arm if not retreating seemed to have stopped. I had regained a bit of feeling in my finger tips. My face was still swollen and my sides ached. I had a few loose teeth I could wiggle with my tongue. But worse was the wound in my thigh. It had gone yellow and the puncture itself seemed not to be healing at all. An infection was setting in and the area of the wound seemed to be spreading.

I rested as much as I dared then resumed my movement hoping to get as much distance as possible between myself the creature.

I found the road the next afternoon. I thought I heard some squealing faintly through the night though I did not see any sign of the animal. To my joy I discovered wagon tracks in

the ruts the road. I stayed on the road from then on moving in a stupor the threat of unconsciousness looming ever near.

I did not hear the beast approach, rather I felt it in the earth. A cloud of dust spewed up in the distance. I had no strength left and my leg had grown black and yellow down to the knee. My breath was shallow due to the pain in my ribcage. Any overt exertion was unbearable.

I could do nothing but stand and wait for the animal to arrive.

It came quickly into view, galloping up the road throwing dust and stones into the air. Somehow it had found me. I pulled the knife from my waist band and placed its tip against my chest thinking I would fall upon it. A quick death might be preferable to what the beast would do.

Then the idea came to me and lowering the knife I reached into my pouch and pulled out one of the remaining coins. I held it at arms length in front of me.

Its effect on the creature was uncanny. The beast stopped a few yards away from me, mesmerized by the coin. Its stance was threatening and I felt it would attack at any moment. Its breath was heavy and coarse.

I tossed the coin toward it. No sooner had it landed on the road than the pig was on it and gobbling it up.

Again the effect was immediate. The coin sedated the pig. Its coat became softer its eyes less fierce. It rolled a few times in the road then trotted happily off into the woods.

It began as a quiver in my stomach, then a painful shaking in my chest until finally it erupted in a great fit of laughter from my throat. I stumbled backward with the force of it and cackled uncontrollably in delirious humor. I had one coin left. Perhaps I could stave off one more attack. After that the price would be my life I was sure. My laughter moved the loose teeth in my jaw and I stumbled forward into the twilight, delirious, the taste of blood slowly filling my mouth, visions of home and family slowly filling my mind.

"It's of no use," came a soft and gentle voice.

"The maggots will eat the infection," the second voice was harsh and deep.

"The leg must be removed."

"Are you prepared to do that?"

There was silence.

"Neither am I," then, "Do you think it's him?"

"Yes, it's him."

"His face is so swollen it's impossible to judge."

I heard all this faintly as if from a distance. Peering through the murk of delirium I saw two round blurs I took to be faces. The rumble of wheels moved through my shoulders and I could see floating before my eyes the statue of the money pig in the village square. It seemed to be breathing. Then its

The impact knocked the air out of me, lifted me off the ground and sent me careening backwards into the water hole.

I landed with my head under water. I gasped for air but drew in nothing but water. A wrenching convulsion took me and I coughed up water even as the hog charged again.

It entered the water at full speed producing a huge splash which momentarily blinded me. This time the water slowed the beast and I managed to escape its impact. I flailed wildly for the far bank. Though the water was not deep it was sufficient to make swimming necessary for the pig and in the time it took for it to get its footing I managed to stumble out of the water and cross the short distance back into the trees. I quit as I could I pulled myself up into one.

The pig broke from the water and shook itself ferociously. Then it charged toward the trees stopping short just at the edge of the clearing. It looked directly at me then but did not enter the wood. Instead it trotted back and forth at the tree line snorting and squealing.

Thus it went for some time. I inspected my wounds. My thigh was deeply punctured. I applied pressure and was able to staunch the flow of blood but the leg was useless. It was numb up into the side of my body. In addition I had a long gash from my left kidney up across my ribs and just passed my sternum.

I jammed a fist into the crux of a limb to steady myself and passed out.

The fall woke me. I came to sprawled on my back in a bed of thistles. With great care and pain I extracted myself from the thicket and crawled back further into the bush. My thigh was a mass of bruised and swollen flesh. My left arm was immobile and feeling it with my other hand I found my shoulder dislocated. The pain in my leg overwhelmed all my senses. I jammed its wrist in-between two tree limbs and with a jerk pulled my shoulder back into its socket. Again I passed out.

When I woke it was pitch black. I could hear branches breaking and the hog snorting. It seemed to be circling around me. I did not move but lay as still as death.

When daylight finally filtered through the tree tops. I dragged myself on my stomach through the wood and made my way back to the edge of the clearing. I did not see the hog. My knife also was not visible. But there in the exact same place where I had placed it lay the gold coin. I knew there was no chance I would be able to defeat the beast. Without strength or weapons my situation was hopeless.

The pig was nowhere in sight and I was terrified.

Somehow I forced myself to crawl around the perimeter of the clearing dragging my leg and favoring my good arm. My head swooned with pain and waves of nausea came and went. I thought I might at least regain my knife and have some protection. I made my way to the edge the thicket and forced myself to a sit up.



Then I heard movement from behind me. The pig was moving toward me. Suddenly the creature burst from the underbrush behind me proceeded to trample me. Its toed feet stomped up my back and shoulders. I screamed and shouted for all I was worth.

The pig retreated back into the bush and I heard it move off until there was only silence.

The right side of my face began to swell. My breath was laborious and with each inhalation I felt sharp pains in my side. Then

I saw the handle of the knife jutting out of the rock near the edge of the water. I had no doubt the beast would kill me in its next attack. I knew there was no escape in my present condition and the knife was my one and best chance of possibly staving off the inevitable. And if another attack occurred I could at least retreat into the water.

I found a stout branch and struggled to my feet. I limped weakly toward the knife. The distance seemed interminably long. Each sound I made terrified me as I thought it would bring the hog back.

No sooner had I come within feet of the knife than the pig came crashing out of the bush. It leapt from the thicket and landed solidly on its stout legs. It issued an ear piercing squeal. It main was stood on end and its ears swiveled independently. Its huge nostrils tasted the air. I fell forward

Hunger prompted this resolve. But hatred sustained it.

This new beast mocked me. It insulted my considered values. Here, after sacrificing everything, stood a version of my nemesis which was completely unaffected by my earlier actions. I slid my fingers into my pouch and rubbed the three gold coins as a plan took shape.

I watched the animal a day and a night. It led me to a small watering hole where upon night fall I refilled my water bag.

Hiding myself near the water I laid one of the coins on a stone near the bank.

I had no idea how a pig became a money pig. I guess I had always assumed they were just bred as such. It occurred to me that this pig might not find the bait enticing. I put my faith in the novelty of the coin in this setting. I only needed it to attract the pigs attention long enough for me to attack.

It took time, much longer then I had anticipated. I was able to observe the beast from a distance. This pig fed mostly on the vegetation of the clearing. I saw here and there the bones of some small rodent it had evidently found and gnawed upon.

It slept much and occasionally for some unknown reason would charge back and forth across the field shaking its head, glorifying in its own being. It would wallow in the mud of the tiny pond then wash itself in the water. Try as I might though I could not decipher any routine which would aid me in bringing down the animal.

Its movements seemed sporadic and arbitrary. Only its frequent visits to the water gave any regularity to its actions.

The gold coin sat untouched on the stone after two days. I managed to eat some berries I found near the edge of the wood but I was getting weak and I feared I would not have the strength to kill the sturdy hog.

Then, my luck changed. The hog came within feet of the coin. It approached cautiously, sniffing the air and stomping the ground a bit with its forefeet. It seemed excited. Once the pig ran by at full speed and in an odd move stuck its snout out toward the coin, twisting its body as it trotted by. It nearly stumbled in the move, but I was now certain it had taken notice of the coin.

I hid myself as completely as I could and waited for its return. I gripped the knife tightly in my fist and knew that I would have only one chance to strike the creature. If I missed it would escape.

The pig circled a few times. The muscles in its shoulders and legs gleamed in the afternoon light. Its tusks seemed incredibly sharp and long and only the intensity of my hatred overcame the fear and awe the thing inspired in me.

Suddenly the hog barreled across the field toward the coin. I could hear it wheeze and grunt as it approached. It got to within a few feet of the coin and skidded to a stop in a cloud of dust. I knew that if the beast took the coin its back would be toward me and I could attack.

That moment came slowly. It stood for what seemed an eternity, then in a smooth motion brought its massive head around toward the rock where the coin lay.

I pounced as soon as it did so. Not only because of the opportunity it presented but also because I did not want the beast to take the coin.

My strength though had faded in my time in the wild. My speed was impaired and my steps were awkward. It was a feeble attempt. I felt no power in the arm which welded the knife and the pig detected me before I had closed the distance between us.

As it turned I dove toward it shouting. But it was fast and turned and crouched. My swing went wide and my wrist struck the bony ridge of its back. I lost

grip of the knife and it clattered against the stones. Somehow I managed to grab a hold of the hair on the hogs back. But the beasts strength was unmanageable. It turned, dragging me across the rocky ground. It was ferocious. It kicked at me with its hind legs as it bucked and twisted.

Somehow I held on. I banged my knees against the stony ground as it flailed and dragged me around. Then, with a huge grunt and an incredible twist of its gigantic neck it caught me in the thigh with one of its tusks. I fell from the beast and sprawled on the rocks. The animal continued its frantic motion until realizing it had freed itself. Then it twirled and faced me, head down, mouth open, its breath hoarse and loud.

I was on my knees, blood poured from the my thigh. My shins and ankles were cut and bruised. No sooner had I got a foot under me then the thing charged.

The hog came barreling towards me. Its head alone was nearly the size of my torso. The pig reached full speed in just a few steps. I could not regain my balance as my leg had gone numb. It charged me its eyes glaring the muscles of its back bunched in knots across its shoulders, positioned so as to give full power to its gleaming tusks. The ground nearly rumbled as it approached. I was up on knee and was no match for the speed of the animal. I could do nothing more than put up my arms in defense.

There is no sound to the dark wetness of spilled blood.

I walked through the night until just the break of day. The sack I carried was soaked through with blood and had mixed with my own sweat creating a foul stench. At dawn I found a hiding place deep in a stand of trees and sleep came to me quickly.

I woke late in the afternoon. My clothing was brittle with dried blood. I pulled out the butcher knife and lay it in the dirt beside the bag. I checked the perimeter of the stand of trees and saw no sign of anyone. I was in strange territory and had only a vague idea of how far I had traveled. Perhaps twenty miles or so. It didn't matter. They would not come after me. They would be busy finding and training a new pig I thought. I dug a hole as deep as I could and started a fire. I nursed it carefully so there would be little smoke. Eventually I had a hot bed of coals. Only then did I take the pig out of the bag.

It was red with blood. Its eyes were wide open and turned upwards. Its tongue hung thick and gray out of its mouth. Its guts had nearly fallen out into the bag. I lay it on the grass and proceeded to clean it in the manner I had studied.

A cheerfulness came over me. In cutting through the pig flesh I found an inner calm, a methodical directness and purpose I had never felt before. At this point, live or die, I felt like I had attained real power.

I pulled the entrails out and put them to the side then rolled the carcass into the pit. I covered it carefully and left it to cook.

Then I turned my attention to its guts. I dug another pit and began stuffing the entrails back into the bag setting aside any portions which might be of use later. When I came to the stomach I hesitated. Curiosity told me to open the thing. So, with the knife I punctured the fleshy bag. A burst of fumes escaped gagging me momentarily. Then I slit it wide open. I had not expected anything but here nestled inside were three gold coins. I snatched them up and wiped them off on my shirt.

It was still daylight when I awoke. After getting my bearings, making sure I could find my way back to the pig, I set off in search of water.

How beautiful the wild was. How self contained. There were no demands here for more or better. Nature created abundantly. The trees, the dense brush, the grass and flowers streamed from the earth. I felt I had walked into paradise.

I knew what I needed to survive. Food clothing shelter. I made a water bag of the pig skin and filled it here and there in small puddles I came across.

I let the meat cook and cook I stuffed myself madly and portioned out the rest. I knew that I had a few weeks before I would need to find additional food. There should be fruits here and there and roots and greens. I had read about a whole crop of things one could eat.

So my second night of freedom began with a feast. I watched the stars, listened to the whispers of the world and feasted on pork, fresh water, and berries.

But the feast did not last. Though I wrapped it and cured it as I had read eventually the meat became too spoiled to stomach.

I had spent hours and hours reading about survival at the village library. But the fact and the information were worlds apart. My own filth became unbearable. The excitement which had sustained me flagged and a constant fatigue set in. I took to rationing my water and in silent moments of hunger I noted the sounds of the world. The birds sang into the night. In the distance I heard squealing which could only have come from some wild herd of pigs. The wind was slight and moved the trees as gently as my mother's hand used to stroke my brow.

Then it was nothing but berries and bark. I could find no fruit or roots my stomach could handle. Eventually hunger drove me to find my way back to the village, but I had wandered too far and was hopelessly lost.

Survival was more difficult than I had imagined. The nights grew cold. And days passed with no rain. I extended my foraging in hopes of finding a steady source of water.

One day, I heard a squeal in the distance and though my strength was fading I chose to seek it out.

The traveling was difficult. At one point I caught a glimpse of a wild pig in the distance and increased my pace hoping the animal might lead me to water. I followed till I could walk no more then fell unconscious to the ground.

I woke to the hot stench of breathing on my face. Above me, snout wet, tusks protruding from the corners of its mouth, stood a hog so large as to be nearly the size of myself. Coarse hair grew in a ratty main down the center of its back. I held perfectly still. This pig looked dangerous. It continued to sniff at me with its moist snout. Its breath steamed in the cool morning air. Its head bobbed a few times as if it were nodding to itself, then it turned and disappeared into the bush. I scramble to my feet as quickly as my strength allowed and placing my hand on my knife went after the creature.

This time it was easy to follow. It was large and left a clear trail through the bush.

For nearly two days I tracked the beast exhausting my store of water. Then finally the wood broke and the pig stopped in the center of a large field. I stayed near the trees and observed the animal.

It stood a few hundred yards ahead of me snout raised, its side facing me. For a few seconds I gazed upon the animal. This was no ordinary money pig. This hog was wild. It stood more nobly than even the bronze statue in town square. This pig seemed the paradigm of pigness.

I resolved to kill the beast.

postscript to thank my father for understanding these concerns. I fold the letter back in the envelope and add it to a pile of clutter on the countertop. The cat squeaks and rolls into a ball.

The cherry of Fawn's cigarette brightens as she inhales then blows patches of smoke lifting into the moonlight. She sits on her porch rocking in a wicker chair, wearing my mother's exotic flower dress. There used to be a picture of my mother wearing it on the mantle. In the picture she's at a beach in Rio de Janeiro with my father, both of their faces bright and sun burnt.

Far off a dog cries to be let back in a house, somewhere. It's quiet enough to hear its rattling chain. The suburbs at night are a vacuous place where simple sounds like a car door shut will tremble through the yards. It's the quiet resolution of the morning bustle, beginning bright and clear and then fading into the cold pallor of dusk with all the TV's flashing blue squares onto the glazed lawns.

Fawn walks to the end of her driveway and flicks her cigarette in the street. I grab a moth and hold it to the lens of my flashlight and shine a monstrous Mothra silhouette onto her garage door. The moth flutters its wings between the pinch of my fingers. It glides over the towering buildings of Tokyo shrieking to wake Godzilla from its subterranean dreams. Fawn's eyes widen in the light.

"Christ," she says. She looks down at my mother's dress she's wearing. "I'm sorry. They didn't sell and I just tried this one on and haven't taken it off yet."

"It's okay. You should keep them if you like them," I say.

"This one is pretty, don't you think?"

"Yes, it is," I say and suddenly I'm standing in the doorway of my parents bedroom. I hear the running water of my father shaving in the bathroom. My mother twirls in front of a mirror. She tells me what a bargain it is. She asks me what I think.

"Let's walk and smoke the rest of those cigarettes," I say.

Fawn and I laugh through the streets named after some local council members we don't know. But it's our world now. The routines of the nine-to-fivers have cast somnolent spells over the neighborhood and it's peaceful, watching moths bang their heads against streetlamps, listening to the susurrus chatter of hidden insects.

For a while we feel like we're the only ones alive on the planet, like that Twilight Zone episode, until two women

jog by, their nylon jumpsuits chaff as they choke out a conversation between their breath. We smoke cigarettes to the nub and flick the speckled filters rolling into the gaps of the disappearing sidewalk behind us. I fall behind to tie my shoe and when I glance up at Fawn's curves shifting in my mother's dress I'm overcome with sad nostalgia, the intimation of remembering myself as a boy fretfully following my mother from sale rack to sale rack in department stores and shopping malls.

A couple streets over from my father's house there's a new cul-de-sac under construction, probably to be named after this Luci chump. There's music coming from one of the houses being built. It sounds like an Oboe with French horn accompaniment, some sort of classical duet. A wire-meshed fence is enclosed around a bunch of scrap waste. Stacks of long boards extend from the gravel darkness of the garage. The house is just a bare skeletal structure. There's an address spray painted on a large wooden plank that leans against the garage. Several of the same planks serve as a walkway to the open front door. A small lamp is clamped to one of the long boards, its orange glow shimmers on a longhaired, bearded man sanding the end of a board. Fawn stops and stares.

I move toward the plank walkway, creeping carefully so not to step on any of the construction adhesive tubes scattered around the mud and rocks of the front yard. Fawn trembles at the end of the

driveway, now a mud hole housing the dirty tires of an old Chevette, every inch of it covered in dust, supplying all of the bored neighborhood scooter posses an easel for their "wash me" renderings. I wave over Fawn, but she's still trepid so I grab her by her hand and squeeze a little confidence into her. She submits and I feel the sweaty quaver of her hands. Mud has caked the bottom of my shoes. The man inside clears his throat and Fawn tenses up. She's probably revisiting our childhood warnings to stay away from construction workers issued by our parents, maybe envisioning the drunk evil we're welcoming, an inhibition hammered in by the over protectiveness of mothers, all of us forced to stay in and play Super Mario Brothers instead of seeking our thrills in the towering darkness of the outside world.

We play a silent little game of tug-o-war for a second and she fights like I'm trying to pull her into a swimming pool. I guess I've done this sort of thing once too often to be surprised, but I persist.

We mount the cinder block foundation of the front porch and I only hear music. The sanding has stopped so we listen for echoing steps on the plank floor. My heart thumps.

"Christ! What kind of madman listens to classical music?"

maybe. People talk. I see women at their front windows; their phone cords coiled around them, the curtains bounce shut at their retreat. I wonder why we are supposed to cover up everything in our lives that is incomplete, like a sheet over a sculpture. What if we let dust gather on the things we neglect?

I receive half-smiles from people walking their chows. They don't even put on their plastic gloves and clean up when Buckley or Rufus bows up by our mailbox.

I walk barefoot down the sidewalk to Fawn's house. Patriotic balloons are tied to her mailbox. Sunlight gleams on the hoods of a Jeep and Mazda parked on the street.

I eavesdrop on two women at Fawn's garage sale, the rusted hangers squeak as they sift through my mother's old pattern dresses, some cotton with painted flowers, some denim with sewn patches.

"It's hideous. We're pitching in and hiring the University Painters. I brought it up at the Civic Association meeting. We really should do something," one of them says, her flimsy hand waves the point home.

Under them, a toddler throws Tigger to the oil and gum stains on the floor. Coins rattle in a tin box. I flip through a wooden crate of records, some Barry Manilow, some Neil Diamond, a frayed Marvin Gaye.

"It's so tacky. They can't live like that," the other one says, craning her neck in sympathy.

I stand by Fawn, who sits in a white plastic chair with a TV tray set in front of her. She fidgets like somebody who's pretending to be busy, like she just walked in on people yelling at each other. I hike my pants up with my fists in my pockets, scanning the folding tables of relics, the empty bike pegs on the far wall, and the panel of an attic on the ceiling. She rests her head on her hand and peaks at me through the corner of her eyes. She opens the tin box for me. There are some wrinkled dollar bills with phone numbers of forgotten one-nighters written on them in ink, draped over a mound of coins. One of them portrays Washington with a black eye and a mustache.

"Hmm," I say. She shuts the box and pours me a cup of iced tea.

I walk to the end of the driveway and look back over my shoulder at the house. It's immaculate, not a single dent in the aluminum siding. The shingles are straight and stiff and

sunlight sparkles in the tiny granules. The lawn is freshly cut and the sidewalk swept clean of its trimmings. A sprinkler hisses like a machine gun and I watch as part of the sidewalk darkens from the drops of water. I swat away a bee. Inside the garage, the toddler struggles for Tigger under the chatting women.

A man in khakis and a button up oxford is shielding his eyes, looking into the front window of my house. He has an unsealed envelope in one hand. Crabgrass brushes against his ankles. He leaves an impression of his hand on the dirty window.

"Something you're looking for?" I say and swallow a big gulp of tea.

"Shit. You scared me. Is your father home?" He fans himself with the envelope.

"Did you ring the doorbell?"

"Yes, but . . ."

"He must not be home then."

"I'm Evan Luci." He pauses, maybe expecting recognition, like some jaded newscaster at the county fair. "President of the Civic Association. Look, we've got a problem here," he looks around at the yard and whistles. "See that your father gets this. My phone number is on there should he have any questions."

My father is slouched in his chair, mouth agape, glasses crooked and dangling from his ear. John Madden scribbles mad play patterns across

the television. A smattering of melted ice wells up at the bottom of his drink. The fat Sunday paper lies refolded on the floor next to him, a corner of a Kroger ad jutting out. My mother's cat, a charcoal long hair, sleeps upside down with its legs up in the air in her chair next to him. I noisily crush my plastic cup in hope of waking him but his heavy breathing maintains rhythm and the cat opens her eyes and closes them.

In the envelope is a letter of notification giving my father a thirty-day warning to make his house presentable. According to Luci, there have been a number of complaints all regarding the house as an "eyesore" and claiming it to devalue adjoining properties. If the house is not made presentable in thirty days, a lawn company and painting company will be hired at my father's expense. Being part of a community wields a responsibility to keep a respectable appearance that will ensure top market value, Luci says. He's polite enough in the

*Walt looks at me with
disapproval, then he
looks across the street
at Sam who nods like
I'm the joke they're
in on...*

eyesores



Benjamin Crites

Tangled in the wrinkled sheets my mother tucked in so long ago, I forfeit sleep to the gurgling lawn machinery. Outside, my neighbors push their mowers and weed whackers. They will sift slow release fertilizer granules into their spreaders and maybe apply a lime treatment to brighten their lawns into glimmering emeralds. They will homogenize their 4,000 square-feet into the collective neighborhood. They will persist.

It's Sunday morning, the weekend, what they work for. It's the motivation that pushes them through the stacks of paperwork at the office - the thought that induces reverie during Power Point presentations.

When you're young you get by with the party, working to slap the check card down on bar tabs. The monotony disappears in frothy mugs of beer. The older you get, you seek quieter, more reticent retreats.

I will never grow old.

I resign to stare through the glaze of my eyes at the spackled webs across the ceiling. Oh, the cacophony. I moan at the throb of my brain receding from the skull. Sunlight hovers like a specter against my beige curtains, feeling for cracks to spill into.

I put on the jeans and tee shirt balled on the floor and sit on the edge of my bed scraping the crusted sleep from my eyes. I part the curtains and squint into the light. Outside the race continues.

Sam across the street has a mound of fecal scented mulch in his driveway. He wears a golf hat and a striped shirt

with a golden bear emblem on the breast pocket. He shovels mulch into a wheelbarrow.

Next door, Walt stretches his serpentine garden hose and mists his rose bushes with a Miracle-Gro formula dispenser attached. Sam Cooke sings about his insufficient knowledge of biology and history from an intercom radio in Walt's garage.

I step outside over the pregnant Sunday paper and stretch, reaching up toward the sun, curling my toes against the hot cement. My shirt lifts and a purple dust bunny pokes its head out of my navel. I inspect it, squinting in the languor of the sunlight. Walt stares at me, then looks across the street at Sam who nods like I'm the joke they're in on.

But they don't see me. They see the clumps of fescue taking over our bluegrass. They see the weeds in the cracks of the sidewalk.

They see the garage door, some of it blue, most of it splotchy green.

My father stopped painting the house mid brushstroke. Maybe the green paint isn't the right color. Maybe he threw up his arms and tossed his tee shirt to the ground, speckled with drops of paint, where it now sits next to a turbid paint bucket thinned with rainwater. The ladder is upright under the gutter. Thick green creeps over the light blue like a seeping spill. Some days it seems it has bled further across the garage door.

I wait for my father to dip his dry paintbrush back into the bucket.

Maybe his arm is sore and he can only shake the feeling back into it so many times. The inspiration left him,

We found her just inside the trees. She had climbed into a small sapling and was huddled on a limb grasping its trunk.

Her father helped her down gently and carried her to the wagon.

He did not say a word to me as he carried her passed. When they reached the wagon she climbed from his arms and disappeared inside. Then he climbed up also. He looked at me then as if measuring my worth. His eyes never left me as he took up the reins. He held my gaze as he threw my knife down to the ground. Then, turning away, he snapped the reins and the wagon moved off.

I limped toward the knife and caught a glimpse of Koshka's hand slip through the canvas at the back of the wagon. She tossed my pouch out onto the road.

Collecting my things I found a place to sit. I stretched out my wounded leg and waited.

It was late afternoon when the boar showed itself. It came from the wood slowly, head bobbing, its snout smeared with blood.

It seemed to look at me with interest now. It did not charge or threaten, but approached fearlessly and with obvious purpose. It knew I had what it wanted. It knew It could take it from me. Perhaps it thought that I was its only source.

I found the coin still in my pouch and held it up in plain sight. The animal fixed its attention upon the coin. I let the gold slip into my palm and held it out in offer. The pig approached. Behind my back I held the knife firmly. As the beast approached I thought about home, and safety, my family and Koshka and her grand father, and as the pig ate the coin I stroked its main softly and prayed, "Heal me. Take me home."

I felt the sun on my shoulders and the dull ache of my ruined leg began to ease.

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A loud squeal pierced the dark silence. The horses began a terrifying commotion and the wagon jerked backwards and forwards. The old man was shouting. "Away! Away!"

I heard Koshka moving as she shouted. "Pa pa!"

"Don't," I said. A terror had grasped me. Somehow I had conjured this wagon as a safe haven. The thought of being left alone unnerved me and the vision of being alone again with the animal filled me with extraordinary fear.

But she did not hesitate and in a moment she had lifted the canvas door was gone outside.

Again the wagon jerked violently, and there came shouts and the horses struggling in their harnesses. The I heard a high pitched wale. "Grandfather!"

"Stay inside," the old man shouted. His voice was broken and weak, more a plead then and order.

I held tightly to the wagon and listened in fearful silence to the commotion outside.

"It's under the wagon!" the old man shouted.

Koshka screamed as the wagon jerked suddenly forward and began moving.

I wanted to move, to climb out and help in some way. But the wagon protected me now and I could not dredge up the courage to even look out and see what was happening. Instead I held fast to my place and begged myself to do something. The thought of facing the red eyed beast again immobilized me and I began to sob as the screaming and shouting outside continued.

I'm wounded, I told myself. They would have turned me in anyway, I thought. I told them to stay inside. I didn't ask for.... But yes I had. In all my actions I had asked for just this. I knew that Koshka and her grandfather would not survive on the ground with the beast.

The wagon slowed to a stop.

I heard a few shouts from the distance then nothing.

I lay there all night. My mind filled with created visions of what had happened. My will could not move my

body and in the passing hours I turned against myself. I was no more than a coward, and now had added two humans to my list of destructions. A self loathing took hold of me and sat like a black coal in my heart.

I could see their bodies in my minds eye and it occurred to me that I would never be free of the beast. It would always be there. I could not comprehend facing the creature again nor could I invasion a method by which I could gain control of the situation.

In the end I could not think at all and sat in this state even as the daylight came.

I do not know if I had fallen asleep but the movement of the wagon seemed to bring me to my senses.

I crawled to the front and out into the sunlight.

One of the harnesses hung lose where a horse had previously been. The remaining stead jumped a bit at my presence then settled down. Blood had dried on its stomach and right leg. It held this leg up off the ground.

The morning was eerily calm. I climbed out on the drivers bench and looked around. The reigns of the horses were wrapped around the pull brake. I could not immediately bring myself to loosen them and I was not sure the horse would be capable of movement in any event.

But I knew I had to go back and see what had happened. The fear in me pushed to grab the reins and run. But shame from my cowardice the night before

was a much greater force.

"Koshka!" I heard the old man shout.

I hurried the horse along. Soon I come upon the old man who was walking along the edge of the road calling into the surrounding wood. "Koshka! Koshka!"

When I approached he turned and looked at me with a rage and hatred that burned through the tears on his face. He turned back to the wood and continued calling.

We both heard the cries at the same time. The old man moved quickly toward the sound. In an instant I forgot my own fear and was climbing down to follow.

*I woke to the hot
stench of breathing
on my face. Above
me, snout wet, tusks
protruding from the
corners of its
mouth, stood a hog
so large as to be
nearly the size of
myself...*

joe bellomy

-31-

The Money Pig

Fawn wants another round of tug-o-war but I let go and she withdrawals back down the planks.

"Christ," I hiss, "What kind of madman listens to classical music?" Stupid question. I tiptoe inside. They haven't installed dry wall yet so there are visible gaps between the support beams. The bearded man sits Indian style on the floor, deflating a faded Cincinnati Bengals bench cushion. I sneak forward but the damn mud on my Nikes comes down in a thump on the floor.

"I don't have the money," the man says in a soft, composed tone, like the voice of a guidance counselor.

"That's okay," I say, "rent's not due until the house is built."

The man turns his head. He's calm.

"You shouldn't be here, this place is dangerous," the man says.

"I don't know. Seems like some solid carpentry," I say, knocking on a wooden beam, twittering nervously at the dualism of it. "We saw a light on and wanted to check it out. Name's Keith."

The man looks back at me and nods. "Well, Keith, you saw lights and decided to check it out. Ballsy, you don't even know what you're walking into. What's this 'we' business? Who you got with you?"

"Fawn," I yell out into the dark. "She's a bit scared. Read the backs of too many milk cartons. Fawn!"

The man stands up and wipes the sawdust off the back of his jeans. He's wearing a black Stryper shirt. His hair is greasy and small strands arch in a sparse nest at the part in the middle. Long tresses drape over his shoulders. He turns off a CD boom box, splashes of paint mottled all over it with a powdering of sawdust.

Fawn shies in behind me. "It's all right, Fawn. I don't think he can fit us in that Chevette with all those tools in there. No carpenter would trade his tools for anything. He'd have to cut us up first," I say.

Fawn loses the color in her face, looks about to lose many things held up inside of her. The man laughs into a fit of coughing and spits. "You got balls," he says, wheezing. "Bigger balls than you know."

Fawn peeks over my shoulder. I feel her shaking hand on the small of my back.

"You can call me Stryper. Step into the light girl, let's see that dress," Stryper says.

I elbow Fawn in the ribs and nod my head. Stryper extends his hand to her and she places hers, soft and quivering, into his and he twirls her. She spins awkwardly, her legs stiff with fear.

"That's some dress, honey. Never seen one quite like it," Stryper says. "You Keith's girl?"

"Not exactly," I say, cutting her off. "We've just known each other forever."

Fawn gasps. Behind the house, a wooded area is full of chirping insects and an owl hoots.

"Hoo-hoo-ha-hooah," Stryper hoots. He hushes us, holds up a hand for us to listen, and then hoots again. The owl is silent.

"Hoo-hoo-ha-hooah," I hoot. Nothing.

"Give it a try, honey. Let's hear your owl call," Stryper says. She backs away from him and retreats behind me.

"Come on, Fawn, let's hear it," I say.

"Hoo-hoo-ha-hooah," Fawn hoots, her voice tremulous.

The owl hoots back.

"See, it likes your sweet voice," says Stryper. He stares into the dark woods, pensively picking at his teeth with his fingernail. "This place is dangerous. Anyone shoot pool?"

Against Fawn's judgment and extensive imploring, we go to Dutch's, a former V.F.W. which draws a menial crowd of drunks, but the pool is only fifty cents a game and the woman in the push up bra at the bar isn't unfriendly with the Jack Daniel's. I expect Fawn to be hesitant. She's the type of person that needs to be pushed off the high dive at the swimming pool, but soon after the section of concrete between the diving well's steel ladder and the ladder of the diving board is drenched with her incessant diving. She needs excitement and doesn't have the means to bring it about herself. Despite all of her fear, I'll show her a good time. Deep down, that's why she's been my friend since childhood, but she wouldn't admit it. She'd have some other way to describe it.

There are deer heads hanging over the bar and I wonder if Richard Hugo fattened his liver here, if this was the Milltown Bar. They have a great old fashioned juke trimmed with neon lights and I'm inclined to throw ten dollars in it on the entire Johnny Cash Live at Folsom Prison, plus some Willy. There are a few stragglers, all of them like sleeping dogs, they raise their heads at the first unfamiliar sound and stare until they feel reassured. The barkeep, Lona, pours me a tall Jack and Coke and a Long Island Iced Tea for Fawn. She eyes Stryper while she sprays Coke from a hose.

"God damnit, Joe," she says. "The shit is real deep this time." She's about to cry.

Stryper and Lona step inside a walk in cooler. Even inside there, I can hear muffled expletives and heavy sobs. Fawn looks at me and I shrug and pull off the double straws until I feel it burn. I'm ready to dull my senses. When the cooler door opens, Lona steps out first and is wiping her smeared eye shadow with a doily or some fancy towel. Stryper's eyes are glassy and he sniffs and begins walking toward us, but Lona seizes him and hugs him real hard and shouts, "Drinks are on the house." It seems we are the only ones real enthused by this, though. The stragglers are essentially



asleep on their folded arms. Fawn is ready for another and I say, sure why not.

"Everything cool, Joe," I say as he settles onto a stool next to me.

"Call me Stryper," he says. He looks at me, a bit troubled but nothing he can't cope with, it seems. "You know how it is with women," he says and smiles a huge, vibrant smile and now we're all ready to move on. Lona, God bless, she's ready to pour, smiling weakly under the smears of her make up.

It takes two Long Island's to loosen Fawn up, but now she's maudlin, going on about how beautiful my mother looked in all those dresses, and how it wouldn't be right if they were sold off to strangers. She tells Stryper how wonderful my mother was and how hard she fought the cancer. Stryper and Lona seem sad by this story.

The word was spoken. Whenever anyone says that word, and I don't want to say it, but whenever they say the deplorable word, I'm forced to recollect the things I tried to drop along the way, like Hansel and Gretel sent back into the woods to collect all the bread crumbs while the witch is burning in the candy house, and all I want to do is forget. It's the type of word that elicits feigned smiles and mine stretches my cheeks unpleasantly, like at the dentist. For a while I feel like some marionette hanging limply over the bar with a painted smile and my lips begin to feel stuck so I suck on the double straws until the hollow sound of the last drops at the bottom of my glass provokes Lona to tip the Jack and draw her Coke hose.

Fawn's twirling has become graceful again. She dances with Stryper and they're laughing. I bum a smoke off Lona and it makes me dizzier than before, but I pull on it anyway and I fiddle with the bar napkin around the bottom of my glass. I ask Lona what the story is with Stryper. Some

people are incapable of fixing their problems, she says. She sighs, long and deep, and her eyes well up.

On the drive back to Fawn's house, Stryper has the Doobies blaring and we all croon out of key, except Fawn, whose voice sounds angelic to my drunken ears. Stryper turns down the radio a moment and looks at us intensely. "Guess this is the time where I'm suppose to chop you up into bits," he says sneering. Fawn and I laugh uncontrollably, and then Stryper laughs and turns the music back up and we're singing again. We drop off Fawn and Stryper pats her ass as she steps out of the car. Fawn giggles and waves. Stryper bounces his eyebrows at me.

In front of my father's house, Stryper's Chevette is idling and I lean into the passenger side window.

"It's nice meeting you, Joe," I say.

"Watch it with that Joe talk," he says.

"I'm wondering if you'll do me a favor," I say, stumbling my words like they're too big and important to get out smoothly.

"What's that?"

"Will you paint my father's house?" I say pointing with my thumb to the dark mass behind me. "I'll pay you."

He considers this for a moment. "Sure, I'll do it, but you can't pay me."

"Sure I can, we have money."

"It wouldn't be a favor if you paid me." He winks, shifts the car in gear, and squeals the tires, jarring all the routine neighbors away from their landscape dreams.

Stumbling up the driveway I'm overcome by blissful peace. I see our house in the dark, where the contrasting paint color isn't clear. Now that Stryper is going to paint the house, no charge, I see brighter days. I see this blissful sensation continuing. I feel I can walk through the streets without everyone craning their necks and gawking at me, without the whispered porch stories, spurned from the very sight of me. It's exuberant, this feeling of possibility, to be born again with a wiser, more optimistic approach to life. I look the house

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Ronny nodded and smiled. "Enough. Just the natives in here tonight, well, except for earlier." I raised my eyebrows. "Oh he was cute. I love a British accent, it's so sexy. I've always been such a sucker for the Sean Connery type."

"God, you're such a hopeless romantic. At least the bird wasn't acting like Bogey."

Ronny clasped his hands and looked up at the ceiling, wishing on a star. "If only..."

"So what's that gee's deal?"

"Well, he's straight, but I'm working on him."

"And?" I slid a twenty-dollar bill across the table under my beer mug.

"And I think he's got some good information. Worth a lot maybe."

I slid a fifty across the table this time. "And?"

"And I think it's dangerous. Very dangerous. Your mark works for MegaSoft's British division, or did. He's a scientist from their biological engineering department. Secret stuff going on over there I hear, growing sentient animals, cloning dinos, et cetera."

"Lots of suits involved?"

"I hope so, an expensive suit is damn sexy. I don't think anyone's caught up to him just yet, but don't worry, they will. Told me he got cold feet. Hopped a plane last night bound here, figuring this would be the place he could sell the dirt he's got, then retire to the Bahamas a rich man. He's so naïve, it's actually kind of cute. But they'll find him, sooner rather than later. I've never seen anyone act so foolish."

"That's why I sent him here. I figured he was a peregrine. I knew that you show people the ropes."

"Well, be a little more careful, please. The two hundred bucks might not be worth it if the shit hits the fan the wrong way. This could be big. The poor baby has no idea what he's doing. Fortunately, I gave him a few pointers. He asked for a room and some security tonight so I called my driver to pick him up and sent him over to my scatter, the Super 10. I offered to come over and watch him myself, but alas, he declined."

I sipped my beer and mulled over all this in silence for a few minutes. "I think I might stop by and have a little chat with our international man of mystery. What room is he staying in?"

"3C. Just tell the bruno at the door that the dog broke its chain, he'll let you in. I'd be careful though, your mark was fingering that toy in his pocket the whole time he was here. He's scared."

Ronny lit a cigarette and sipped his margarita, which glowed under the blacklight in the corner. I noticed the motes of dust standing out on my jacket as well, like tiny invisible diamonds forced into the light. "Thanks Ronny."

I walked back up to the bar and saddled up on a vinyl barstool next to Ruth. She lifted a wrinkled brown palm and patted me on the shoulder. "Well, looks like you did take time out to stop and say hello to an old friend after all."

"Hi Ruth. What are you drinking? Whatever it is, order another on me." She signaled O'Mally, who filled a heavy tumbler with ice and bourbon. "How are things? You still doing all right?"

She turned and glared at me through those milky eyes, the irises half blanketed by cataracts. "If you mean, am I ready to retire myself to an old folks home, you can kiss my black ass. I may take a little longer to get around, and I suppose I might have to get me a wheelchair one of these days, but I'll be dead drunk before I wind up in one of them places. You know they don't let you drink in there, don't you? Besides, I'd be bored. What am I gonna do, trade cigarettes to find out who's wearing dirty underwear that day?"

"Ruth, Ruth, I'm sorry. That's not what I meant."

"Well then, I'm just fine. Now what's the dig on that foreign boy was in here earlier?"

I briefly gave Ruth a rundown of what Ronny had told me, coupled with the proceedings of the afternoon. "So what do you think? Have you heard anything about these MegaSoft goons?"

She frowned, clinked the ice cubes together in her glass, and sipped the last bit of watered down whiskey from the glass, then pulled the fresh one in front of her. "I don't know nothing about them international corporations. I steer clear of them. They keep their secrets to themselves, and anybody who uncovers them winds up missing, never to be heard from again. I ain't never heard of nobody two-timing one of them corporations and not disappearing."

"I'm not a gambler, Ruth, but this sounds good, real good. If I can put the screws to this meat, I know I can soak it for hard hack on the street, easy. And this goose can go and sell his dope to some other corporate suits and get himself blipped off if he wants to." O'Mally brought me another beer, and I sipped it slowly, licking the heady foam from my lips.

Ruth fell silent and shook her head. She pursed her lips slowly, then spoke in a whisper. "You do what you want. But about twenty years ago, I had a gentleman friend who got his hands on some kind of finance records for MegaSoft. He planned to sell them to an IRS agent he had on the lam. A week later, police dragged up a body from the river, claimed it was my boy. But I went to the funeral and I saw the casket. It sure wasn't him. My friend was gone and there ain't no one heard from him since. But you do what you want." She sipped her drink and fell silent, a heavy frown dragging down her sagging cheeks.

I slipped a twenty in her handbag and dropped a ten on the bar for O'Mally, then walked outside.

I hate the smell of the city at night. All the car exhaust sinks down to street level and steam rolls out of the sewers. The water in the gutters is black like tar, and you never know if that sound behind you was a raccoon digging for its dinner or a thug about to stick a knife in your spine. I leaned against the brick wall of O'Mally's, felt the nylon fibers

"Hey, people have to make a living somehow, hon."

"Yeah, but do they have to send their kids out to do it? I mean, come on, that girl should have been at school."

I shrugged and drank my beer. I didn't bother to mention that I'd been shadowing people between classes by the time I was twelve for money to buy soda and cigarettes. "I'll do a sweep of the building on Saturday, see if they've stuck any wireless bugs anywhere."

"How was your day?" she asked. "Pick up any right rags going around?"

"Not really. Well, there was this one bird. Real rube, a peregrine I guess. Guy's acting completely obvious, running around in this James Bond getup and asking to meet someone, anyone, who he can sell some dope to. I sent the guy over to O'Mally's just to get him out of there. There were at least three people tailing him already."

"What's the wire on him?"

"No clue."

"Why didn't you get a slant? If this guy's such a sap, he should have been easy to chisel."

"Sure I could have. But I didn't want to step on any toes. I've got a great job that a lot of other people would like to have. I got it because I never tip my mitt and I always play wise. I do good work, I find out the rap for people, and that's it. There could be half a dozen hits on this mark for all I know, and I don't want to get my nose cut off if I don't know what I'm sticking it in. And besides, I felt bad for the guy. He'll be lucky if he doesn't get a shiv in the back walking across the street. Ronny will help him out, get him on the bulge. And then I can talk to Ronny and find out the peach on him. I want to find out who sent him to me."

"But you run the information desk at the Public Library, anybody who knows anything comes to you to find it out."

"Yeah, but this guy didn't know anything, and he put me in a dangerous spot."

"But if the mark does get poked before he gets to O'Mally's?"

"Nobody will bother him. Like I said, nobody knows who this guy is. Could be a runaway from some megacorporate bombshell with bigwig suits after his ass. Nobody wants to toss in their chips until they know what the stakes are. Anyway, what's for dinner?"

"I thought we'd order Chinese."

"As long as it's not from Oriental Emperor. Last time we ordered from there I found metal shavings in my fried rice, remember?" I shook my head. "It's damn unprofessional. Who were they trying to kill, you or me? I mean, if you're trying to bop someone, you ought to have better odds than fifty-fifty, am I right?"

3

Later that evening after Evelyn and I made love, I got up and dressed. I wanted to stay in bed and relax, I should have stayed in bed and relaxed, but my curiosity got the better

of me. I looked at her form lying in our bed, traced the curve of her hips up to her breast with my eyes, and saw the shadow of her nose under the dim lighting. Evelyn and I have been together for four years. The first six months of our relationship she was just seducing me for information to sell to her employer. This woman, Rebecca, was trying to use Evelyn, who was also sleeping with the assistant director of the Public Library at the time, to keep me from getting the promotion to Information. She was also one of the possible candidates for the job. Well it goes to show you that love is more important than money, even in this city, cause we fell in love and she told me about the setup. She provided me with info I needed to get our assistant director shitcanned, and the director gave me the promotion to Information thanks to her. I promptly screwed up Rebecca's sources and contacts, and she quit shortly afterwards. Evelyn and I have been together ever since. I figure she probably sells me out left and right, as long as it's nothing serious enough to get me killed. I have to admit I've traded information about her jobs more than once to a contact or two of mine. We love and trust each other, and both understand that the lack of confidentiality just comes with the way of life.

I moved silently through our apartment, gathering a few things and thinking again about that tight-lipped smile she gave me earlier. I stopped in the spare bedroom that we shared as an office. A pair of envelopes lay on the desk. One envelope was white, business size, and had the address of Evelyn's doctor on it. The other was a large manilla envelope. Laying on top was a black and white photograph of a man in a suit holding a young girl's hand. They were standing in front of a sleazy-looking motel. Something struck me odd about the picture, and I held it up to inspect it. Behind me I heard Evelyn stir. I didn't want her to catch me snooping, so I shut out the lights and left the apartment.

The April evening air was warm so I decided to walk the six blocks to O'Mally's. I turned down a couple of streets and sidestepped into an alley to make sure no one was tailing me. Not that it mattered so much, anybody who knew me at all knew I was a regular at O'Mally's dive. The front door was standing open and cigarette smoke was rolling out, accompanied by the rollicking horns of an old jazz standard. Two young couples were drinking beers and employing the pool tables near the door. Old O'Mally himself was running the bar, half a dozen locals were sitting around it. One guy I recognized as a small time fence, another guy was a shadow, and Ruth traded in information, like myself. She'd been doing it since she was a teenager, back in the thirties and forties, had worked with my dad in the sixties and seventies, and was mostly blind now, but she noticed me come in and simply nodded her head.

There were a few people at the tables. A fat shadow in the corner I knew to be Ronny sat alone, nursing a margarita. I went up to the bar, O'Mally was already filling me a beer. I carried it over to Ronny's table and sat down. "This place deaf?" I asked.

"Don't worry about it." I scratched an address down on a slip of paper and slid it across the desk to him. "Why don't you try this gin mill tonight, Mac. They've got a wicked vodka gimlet there."

"Vodka gimlet? Sir, I'm afraid I'm in need of more than a stiff drink."

"Just trust me. Head over there and ask for a vodka gimlet. It will help you get your bearings." What can I say? I felt sorry for the guy. He was making himself into the biggest walking mark I'd ever seen. It was really comical.

*"I thought we'd
order Chinese," she
said.*

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"I'm most gracious sir, thank you." I started to ask who had told him to come in here for information, but he was already shuffling across the marble floor, looking as conspicuous as a fox in a hen house. Only it was the other way around.

2

I took a taxi over to the Snack-O-Mart Deli three blocks east of my apartment just to throw off my cabby, who would almost certainly sell this information to someone, and also to pick up the potato chips and pimento loaf my wife

asked for when she had called that afternoon. We didn't really need chips or pimento loaf—hell we both hate pimentos—but we had to maintain pretenses. Every phone in this goddamned city was tapped, and my office phone was no exception. She had called from our cell phone, which was pretty safe unless someone was hacking the signal to listen in, to let me know the Davises down the hall were planting bugs throughout the apartment building. That's what pimento loaf meant.

I carried a bag of chips up to the counter. I knew the clerk pretty well, since I'd been coming in here a couple times a week for the two years Evelyn and I had lived in our apartment. "How you doing today, Jack?"

"Not bad, John. I also need a deck of reds, a half pound of pimento loaf...oh, and a box of five-hundred watt light bulbs."

"You got it, pal." He scooped the pimento loaf into a small plastic tub, loaded the tub, the chips, and the cigarettes into a plastic sack, and punched a few keys on the register. "Seven seventy-five plus the bulbs."

I handed him three twenties and said, "Keep the change." I scooped up my bag and exited through the back door into the alley. As I walked up to the back door of my building I heard the telltale momentary hum of the power surge that would fry all of the delicate sensory equipment the Davises had installed earlier that day. You can get just about anything at the Snack-O-Mart these days if you know what to ask for. When I was a kid if you wanted to fry out a bunch of bugs you had to go buy a couple of car batteries, wire them together, and then use jumper cables to hook them up to the electric meter or the phone box or whatever, all without blowing yourself to kingdom come. Ah, the conveniences of modern living.

Evelyn already had a cold beer open for me when I entered our apartment. I kissed her and sat down at the formica bar that divided our kitchenette from the living room. The apartment wasn't much, but the rent was cheap, the place was warm, the landlady, Ms. Lauder, hadn't tried to scam us or sell us out, and it provided a nice view of the city. "How was your day, baby?"

She went through the bag I brought home and tossed the pimento loaf in the trash then took out the cigarettes and lit one. "It was okay. I spent most of the morning tailing a highpillow from NetCom who was kicking it with some chippy jane whose wife did the math. I clipped some mugs, hand developed them, sent one set to a P.O. box and another set to his old lady. I'm supposed to meet with her next week to arrange for the rest of the cabbage. When I came home this afternoon I caught the Davis girl doing the jigsaw on our door and I guessed that they'd been setting bugs around the building again. Sure enough, I went next door to Mrs. Morris's place, and they'd tagged her phone and her bedroom while she was out grocery shopping. I might say something to Ms. Lauder about them if this happens again." Evelyn finished with a tight-lipped grin on her face, and I knew she wasn't telling me something. I decided not to press it.



Shannon Rampe

I knew from the moment I saw him that this guy was a hack. I mean, nobody saunters in here on a Tuesday afternoon wearing an Armani suit, black sunglasses, and carrying an Italian leather briefcase. If that wasn't bad enough, the guy keeps one hand in his coat pocket, a sure sign that he's packing, and he keeps stopping and looking around to see if anyone is following him. Hell, of course people were on his tail. I saw at least three shadows, some teenage punk girl, a leggy businesswoman, and a blonde guy in a Yankees jacket. This guy had to be from out of town, way out of town. Even if he was just a local boob he'd have more sense than that. I had more sense than that in kindergarten.

The guy made no pretense about what he was doing there. He marched right up to my desk and leaned over, pulling his sunglasses down to the tip of his nose. "I need some information," he whispered in a fake British accent.

I turned around and looked up at the sign hanging above my desk. "INFORMATION" was printed in large white block letters on a brown sign. "Well, it looks like you got the right desk, Mac. Give me an author's name and I can throw you the title, or vice versa. You'll have to check over at the circulation desk to see if it's in right now. If you're after Fleming, they're probably all checked out."

"Ah, no. Forgive me, I don't think you understand. I have some confidential files," he said this with a hiss, "that I think would interest quite a few people around here." He took his hand out of his pocket and patted his briefcase. His fingers left an oily smudge on the fine leather, assuring me that he was indeed carrying a pistol in his pocket.

I decided to continue with my ignorance routine, only to squeeze a little something out of him for the sake of the guy in the Yankees jacket. He'd helped me out a few times before by dropping me headers about who was coming in or passing notes on the library steps. The front of the Public Library is a popular meeting place because it's out in the open and fairly safe. Few people are ever clipped there, too much traffic. And besides, it was sort of a given that it was neutral ground. As neutral ground as anywhere in this city, I guess. "What kind of files, Mac? Hey, Mac, files, that's kind of funny, ain't it? Like computers, you know?"

"Look, Mister..." he glanced down at the brass nameplate in front of me. "Anderson..."

"Just Anderson, cut the Mister, Mac."

"Anderson, excuse me. I don't think I can say right now." He leaned close again and whispered. "I think there is a woman following me."

"You don't say?" I gave him my best expression of surprise. "There's at least two other people tailing you too, Mac." The punk girl sneered at me over the top of a Rolling Stone magazine she was leafing through.

The man looked around him again, clutching the briefcase. "Who? Who else?"

over, the sky spins above me and I almost fall over. I see an owl perched on the apex of our roof, its breast puffed out and head jerking to the side. Its talons clamped to loose shingles. "Hoo-hoo-ha-hooah," I hoot. The owl is quiet and motionless like some stone gargoyle or statue. Its eyes stay focused on me as I walk in the house.

Inside my father sleeps on the couch, the open TV Guide rising and dropping with the movement of his chest. The TV is off air and the black and white speckles of white noise fill the room with the sound of rushing water. My mother's cat lies on the kitchen table, scanning out the window for the stealthy critters of night. I pass my parents' bedroom in the hall upstairs. I stop, lean my wobbling body against the doorframe of my bedroom, and go back to my parent's room and flip the light on. There's the violet comforter and all the matching paintings and fake flower arrangements sitting placidly under the dust. I turn off the light, fall into their bed and dream about finding my first bicycle, which was sold many years ago in a garage sale. In my dream, I find it in a cave on the gray beach of a desert island one stormy night.

Just after six the next evening, I arise from my dark room to someone pounding on the front door. I squint at the light that pushes through the open door and it's a shadowy figure of Luci, grinning like a politician.

"Is your father home?" he asks.

"Nope," I say, drooping at my pulsing hangover.

"Clearly that's his car in the driveway," he says and points at my father's Accord.

"Clearly," I say.

"Did you give him the letter? I thought for sure he'd call. I want to make sure he understands our point of view on the matter."

I start to close the door but Luci wedges his foot in.

"Our intentions are for the good of the community. He understands that?" he asks.

"Clearly," I say.

Luci scoffs down the driveway, the lapels of his suit jacket lifting against his stride.

I walk the hallway to the family room. The house is dark except for the lamp on the end table by my father's chair, which casts a soft glow on a large U-haul box. It sits in front of my father who has kicked off the loafers and his black socks

are in balls beside them. His tie is loose around his neck. He looks at me and puts a finger to his lips to shush me, then waves me over. I stand over the box and my father looks wild, his eyes beady and intense. I watch his hairy knuckles, the wedding ring still on his finger, as he methodically lifts each box flap. Inside the box is a one-eyed Great Horned Owl. The socket of the missing eye has crusted blood and white puss in a mesh of pink and red. The owl stands stiff as the night before, though I can't be sure it's the same owl. Its plumage of brown and white tufts of feathers expands and contracts. We are silent in the hold of its single eye.

"I'm going to the animal hospital," he says. "You're on your own for dinner."

I watch my father load the box in the back seat of his Accord. He hurries into the driver's seat and speeds out of the driveway and disappears from my view at the window behind Walt's massive poplar.

I eat a ham sandwich while I flip through the TV. Someone has found an easy way to clean gutters. Someone has found a perfect way to make an omelet. I find nothing so I steal a six-pack from my father's Monday Night Football stock of Miller Light and decide to visit Stryper. It's quiet in the gloaming of the neighborhood. All the busy bees are nesting, all the garage doors shut, and all the dinner plates stacked in the kitchen sink.

It's nearly dark when I shuffle through the gravel driveway and up the planks of Stryper's construction site. This time there isn't any classical music playing.

Inside I find Stryper tied up in an uninstalled bathtub, his hands bound with copper wire, his eyes cut and swollen, his mouth taped shut. He's wearing only a shabby pair of boxers. When I reach to pull the tape from his mouth, tires dig into the gravel. The house is lit with the headlights of four cars. I kneel down to Stryper and place my hand on the back of his head to support his neck. I shield my eyes from the light. I see dark figures stepping out of the cars. Some of them are carrying shotguns. They all seem to be wearing suits. Stryper doesn't look forward, but into my eyes. His bangs are crusted with blood. The steps crunching in the gravel get closer, but the light . . . it's penetrating. The shapes cast shadows over us, but I look off beyond them, squinting blindly into the white light, thinking this is a dream, that I'll wake to the scent of fried bacon and my mother rummaging through cupboards in the kitchen.



of my jacket cling to the bricks, and watched a prostitute a block away across the street. She was young, still pretty even. I didn't see any pimps around, so I guessed that she was new to this. Her shoulder length hair was bleached blonde, and under the dead light of the street lamp, the eyeshadow she wore made her eyes into dark pits. She had curvy hips and a bright smile. She wore a bright red miniskirt and a sparkly top. She stepped carefully in her black leather heels up to the curb as a white sport utility vehicle slowed to a crawl. She called out to him and shook her breasts back and forth. The van stopped and the passenger side door swung open. The girl skipped across the headlights of the SUV, leaving a pair of brief silhouettes on the pavement, and climbed in, pulling the door shut behind her. The vehicle pulled away from the curb and sped into the night, leaving behind nothing but the stink of burnt gasoline drowning out her little cloud of perfume, which itself was trying to drown out her own very human smells.

As I walked down the block, my thoughts were spinning. I wasn't one to take dangerous risks, that's why I'm still alive and had the job at the library. I made decent dough at the Information desk, but turned around and spent most of it on more dirt, that's the way the job worked.

That's the way everything works in this town. And then I thought about Evelyn. We had traveled upstate the week before to her younger sister's wedding. The event was set on a country hill in the spring sunshine, clover and dandelions bursting out everywhere. Everyone was happy, my niece and nephew from Evelyn's older brother were angelic, not a hurtful word was spoken, and I felt a deep emptiness inside. It made me think about being a father. Evelyn and I talked about it that night. We came to the conclusion that we lived a different lifestyle. Neither of us wanted to raise kids in this city. If they didn't wind up being dips, guns, pro skirts, or hop-heads, they'd wind up chilled off.

"I love my job, though," I had said, lying in bed next to her.

"Mine isn't so bad either," she had replied.

"Warped as it is, I've adapted to the lifestyle here. It's all I've ever known."

"So have I," she had replied, trying to back me up. I could see in her eyes that she didn't really feel it, that she was just trying to be rational, reasonable, use common sense. We

didn't have the money to leave the city. We were finally getting stable. In another five or ten years maybe...

"It's all I've ever known."

So I stood in the shadow of O'Mally's, the same gin mill where my father had gone for his evening drinks back when he ran guns, back before he was drilled in the back by a mobster who knew what kind of kif he was carrying one night. I stood in that shadow and I looked out across this sick and dead city, and I wanted to leave. I wanted to smell grass, climb oaks and poplars, swing under a weeping willow. I wanted to see a rabbit, or a raccoon that lived on something besides human waste. I was tired of concrete, tired of glass and aluminum, bored with honking and car exhaust, tired of the midnight cries, nauseated by the morning news, bodies in the river. I was sick of it all. It was all I'd ever known.



5

I suppose I'd made my decision before I'd even left the apartment, because I had my .38 strapped under my shoulder, and a camera, our cell phone, and lockpicks in my pockets. I circled through the same three or four blocks half a dozen times to throw anyone who might have been on my tail, then hailed a hack and rode fifteen minutes over to another bar just a block south of the Super 10. After scouting around the block, I entered through the service door in the alley, which was unlocked. I kept my head down and my jacket collar pulled up, in case

of any hidden cameras. I ran up the stairs in threes and stopped in front of a tan steel door with the giant number "3" stenciled on it.

I entered the hallway and told the granite slab of a guard that the dog had broken its chain. "Go grab yourself some hooch on me, pal." I slapped a ten in his palm. "Give me fifteen." He shrugged and walked off towards the elevator. Thinking I might be able to catch my mark asleep and make a clean sneak, I started to fumble with the lockpicks, but realized after a few seconds that the door was unlocked. I just shook my head.

I opened the door and slipped into the room as quietly as possible, carefully closing the door behind me. I turned around to see the barrel of a pistol in my face.

"Whoa there, William Tell, take it easy!" He was sweating and his hands were shaking enough that he might have actually missed me if he had fired.

"Oh, its you," he said in that fake-sounding accent. He lowered his gun. "Please excuse me. My nerves are a bit rattled."

about the contributors

For this issue, Joe was the art director and staff artist, Nathan was the chief editor and layout artist, Ben was the chief proofreader, and Shannon was laid up in bed with a broken something-or-other. All story and artwork rights belong to the contributor. We would appreciate any reader feedback, so feel free to email us at all hours of the night about any issue you feel competent discussing.

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Ben Crites received his B.F.A. in 1999 from Bowling Green State University. He currently resides in Columbus where he is a journalist. Ben can be reached at ben_crites@yahoo.com

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Mauled by typewriter at four, nasally impaled by pencil at eight; hopes this magazine will not be the last round in his battle to the death with the writing profession. Inexplicably got a B.Sc. in Geology from OSU in 1999. Can be seen pacing naked in his apartment, pantomiming ctrl-F or teaching hands-on science (fully clothed) in Columbus. aelffin@hotmail.com

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Joseph Bellomy

echoterra183@cs.com was born in this place without knowing why. Has had a particular language imposed upon him along with particular ideas. Has often wondered wandered, and wobbled. Has jumped in a lake, gone and flown a kite, and taken many flying leaps.

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the showdowns in the westerns I watched on television as a boy. I stuffed the binoculars in my pocket, holstered the pistol, and walked out of the front door of the library. Two men stepped out of the SUV; suits. Ronny would have been in love. I held up the briefcase. The suit from the passenger side opened the door and Evelyn climbed out of the vehicle. I walked forward slowly and the second suit led Evelyn up to the sidewalk. The first suit kept his gun trained on me. "I wish to thank you, Mister Anderson, for your prompt assistance in this matter."

"Kiss my ass," I said. I sat the briefcase down at the bottom of the Library steps. The second suit let go of Evelyn's arm and picked up the briefcase, then backed away. He was also carrying a gun. My heart thumped hard in my chest, my hands were clammy. I'd had too many guns pointed at me that night. Evelyn wrapped her arms around me and I held her close. Her lip was swollen and bloody, but her face grim, her eyes dry.

"I have to tell you something," she whispered.

"Well, chaps," I said, "since you've got your briefcase and I've got Evelyn, we're just going to take off now."

"I set this all up," she whispered again. "I heard about the peregrine and sent him to you. I thought it would be easy money."

"Ah, not quite yet sir," said the first suit. "You of course understand that I have to examine the case to make sure it hasn't been tampered with. And then of course, I'll have to shoot you both."

"I know. It's okay. I love you," I whispered to Evelyn. Then I called out to the suit. "I've seen enough plugs fly tonight, thank you. And you'll want to watch that case, it's a Koenig model 472 and if you miss the right combo, it goes boom."

The suit ignored me and fumbled with the little golden suitcase dials. "Ah, there we go," he said as he flipped open the latches. I grabbed Evelyn's arm and pulled her to the sidewalk under me. The briefcase exploded in a burst of flame, incinerating the suit who was holding it, and blowing the other into the SUV. I pulled Evelyn behind a statue of Abe Lincoln and the SUV exploded like a small volcano. "Goddamn gas hogs."

I couldn't help it. I started to laugh. I looked at Evelyn, saw the tears standing in her eyes. I helped her to her feet, heard my own knees creaking as I stood up. "I'm too old for this stuff. It's time to retire. Let's scoot, more button men will be here soon." She nodded and we hobbled down a dark alley hand in hand.

"So you set me up."

She looked into my eyes, trying to read my expression, trying to figure out how angry I was.

"I figured it out when I saw the photos. Then I rang Patrick. He cracked the box for me then altered the combination. But honey, if you wanted to move, I would have taken a second job."

She shook her head. She was crying now. "It wasn't just moving. Getting another job would have taken too long. I'm pregnant."



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I had the cabby let me out in front of the Snack-O-Mart Deli and I walked the remaining two blocks back to my apartment building. The butterflies of excitement had metamorphosed into little worms of anxiety deep in my gut. I kept feeling like I had forgotten to watch one of my bases and a runner had stolen third right under my nose. I came to the door of my apartment and my heart skipped a beat as I saw the lock had been forced. I put my hand to my shirt pocket and remembered the business card.

I pulled the .38 out of its holster and pushed the door open with my foot. The apartment was silent. Nothing seemed in disarray. I moved quickly through the living room, bedrooms, and bath. Evelyn was gone. I stopped in the spare bedroom when I saw two envelopes. I thought it was odd that Evelyn hadn't mentioned any doctor visits to me. Then I picked up the photo lying on the manilla envelope. These were the photos Evelyn had taken that morning, the ones of the NetCom bigwig and his mistress. Something was wrong with this picture, and when I examined it closely, I realized what it was. Her man wasn't a NetCom bigwig at all. All the NetCom highpillows shaved their heads, even the women, as some kind of corporate ritualistic behavior. This guy had a full head of hair. I emptied out the contents of the envelope on the desk and stared dumbfounded. There were several more photos of her bigwig and his girlie, and also a personal dossier, identifying the man as a MegaSoft CEO. Behind these were three photos of my now-deceased English friend.

I sat down on the couch and let the pistol and the briefcase fall to the floor. I dropped my head in my hands and tried not to panic. I tried to think of any rational reason for Evelyn to leave without locking the door. What the hell was going on? She knew about the peregrine before I did. She would have been using microphones and bugs on her target as well,

and I guessed that he had taken a call concerning the runaway. She had gone after him then and apparently sent him to me. But why? I looked up at the message board by the phone. On it was written in Evelyn's hand a name and a number that had not been there earlier: Patrick 229-5007. And the message light on the phone was blinking.

I pressed the play button: "Mister Anderson, the briefcase you have is important to us and useless to you. Your wife is useless to us and important to you. Ergo, a trade should be made. In front of the library at two a.m. Thank you." The machine beeped at the end of the message. The voice was cold and businesslike. I shivered. I was scared and angry. I knew this was all her fault somehow, some plot of hers. But what could I do? I love her.

I picked up the phone and dialed Patrick.

7

An hour later I was inside the library, the briefcase in one hand and the .38 in the other. To my comfort, the place was empty. I'd brought my thermographic binoculars along this time and peered out a second story window to the street below. It was empty. I scanned the windows of the office buildings across the street for any gunmen. Empty again. I put down the binoculars and looked out the window in a sad sort of way. The city was almost beautiful at night. From this

height you could look down and see the park where no one took their children to play, the river beyond that and then a line of ashy tenements against the night sky. I thought of Evelyn again. Why had she done this? Then I remembered the wedding, the empty look in her eyes that night as she reluctantly agreed with me. We just didn't have the money to move out of the city. I stared at the suitcase in my hand. "Goddamn..." I whispered. I rubbed my eyes, keeping the wetness away.

A black SUV stopped in front of the Library. The streetlamps gave everything a pallid orange tint. I thought of

I was tired of concrete, tired of glass and aluminum, bored with honking and car exhaust, tired of the midnight cries, nauseated by the morning news, bodies in the river.

"That's understandable. You're running around practically begging for a knife in the back."

He looked a little miffed at that. "Well, I'm just trying to do my best. I'm just trying to stay alive. Anyway, I understand that you are the fellow I need to deal with to arrange a trade. You know people who might be interested in what I have to sell, correct?"

I pulled a business card from my shirt pocket and stuck it in his hand, then made my way into the room. "That depends on what you've got to sell. Let's have a look, shall we?" I walked to the dresser where the briefcase lay shut. I knelt down and peered carefully at the six gold dials, each stenciled with a set of black numerals.

"Wait! Don't try to open it!"

"Why not? If you want to sell this stuff to somebody, and you need me to figure out who to sell it to, and arrange the trade, I've at least got to know what you're selling."

"Well... yes, but..." He twisted up his face in obfuscated British knots. "The briefcase is armed with a bomb. If you try to open it and it isn't unlocked properly, it will explode."

"I know. It's a Koenig model 472. Packs the punch of a hand grenade if you miss the right combination."

"Couldn't I just sort of tell you what's in there?"

I looked up at him and gave him an expression like he was the dumbest biscuit in the dog's dish.

"Oh, damn it all! Fine, I'll open it."

There was a loud crash and the door slammed open. The deafening rhyme of a submachinegun erupted from the hallway, and my mark fell face forward onto the bed. A red stain was blossoming on the back of his Armani suit. The only thing I could think was, "that's gonna be a tough stain to get out." Staying low, I pulled the suitcase off the dresser and hid behind the far side of the bed. Another short spray of bullets whizzed over my head, lodging in the wall and breaking open the sliding glass door that let out onto the fire escape.

I yanked out my pistol and fired a pair of return shots over the bed at the black-suited gunmen in the hallway. My heart thud in my chest and I rushed forward as fast as I could on my hands and knees, cutting my fingers on the bits of broken glass. As soon as I was on the fire escape, I bolted down the stairs and dropped from the second floor landing into the alley. I heard shouting from the room above me and screaming from other tenants of the hotel. I ran across the alley between two apartment buildings and another spray of bullets exploded the bricks a few feet from my right arm. I whispered a string of obscenities under my breath and ran, the briefcase flailing in my left hand.

A figure lit out from the shadows ahead of me, and a meaty fist collided with my chest. I dropped to the ground gasping for breath and lost my grip on the pistol. The button man wasted no time in kicking me in the stomach, knocking me onto my back, and leaving me dizzy. He raised that steel-soled Oxford high above my head. I rolled back just in time to avoid facial reconstructive surgery. Behind me I could hear

two pairs of feet hurrying down the fire escape. "Don't let him get away Roxy," said one of the men.

"Roxy?" I inquired as I rolled to my feet and fumbled in my pocket. "You dance the Can Can or something?" I was still crouched over and gasping for breath.

"Let me show you," he said. He took a step forward and drew his leg back to punt me like a football. As his foot whistled forward, I danced to the side, caught his foot, and gouged a lockpick pin into his ankle. Roxy screamed, lost his balance, and fell to the concrete with a dissonant crack. I snatched up the briefcase and my pistol and ran, firing a shot blindly behind me. Two bullets whistled past me in return, the echoes of the guns were deafening in the tight alley.

Still wheezing hard, I ducked into another alley, climbed on top of an aluminum trashcan, and leapt for an open window in the abandoned tenement building before me. As I swung over the window ledge, I felt the vibration as a slug buried itself in the other side of the wall. I fired another blind shot back at them, and rushed through the building, this time hurrying up the stairs to the roof. Roof hopping was one of my specialties in my youth, and I made good use of the experience then. Most of the tenements and office buildings were jammed close enough together that hopping from roof to roof or roof to fire escape was nothing more than heavy exercise.

After I felt I was a sufficient distance away I hailed a cab and gave him a messy set of directions in case he was being tailed by anyone. Then I collapsed against the vinyl seat and tried to catch my breath, picking the bits of glass out of my hands. I hadn't run like that since my car thievery days. I tried to examine the briefcase, but it was too dark in the cab. Instead, I pulled out the cell phone and called Evelyn.

She picked up on the third ring. "Hello?"

"Sweets? It's me. Look, I'm behind the eight ball!"

"What? Are you okay? What happened?"

"That meat was a peregrine gone awol. I went in to give him the third but some hatchetmen showed up and let the daylight in. The meat's on ice, but I got the keyster."

"Jesus! What the hell were you thinking? You're not eighteen anymore."

"I know. But this is the case dough. As soon as I find my butter and egg man, we'll have the bees, then we can sneak and buy that country home." I put my fingers on the latch of the briefcase, thought about the bomb inside. "I need your help though. You still know that can-opener?"

"Yes."

"Good. Get his number ready. I'm gonna drop him a dime as soon as I get home. This one is a trick-or-treater."

"My god. Be careful!"

"I will. I love you." I shut off the phone and dropped it back in my pocket. Then I sat back and tried to calm down. I had a bad stitch in my side and sweat was pouring down my face. I was half-afraid that after all this craziness, I was going to drop dead in the back of a cab from a heart attack.

Respect the Pig

